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Philippians 1:1–11

Philippians

Philippians 1:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 1:1—11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:1—11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Paul is in prison in Rome in the early 60s A.D. Paul is in prison because Paul has been preaching the gospel, or good news, about Jesus. As a Roman citizen, Paul has appealed to Caesar, the leader, or "emperor," of the Roman Empire, to judge Paul's case at the highest level, and Paul waits to hear what Caesar will decide.

Stop here and look at the map. Find Rome as a group. Pause this audio here.

Nobody knows for sure if the authorities will release Paul and give him freedom to preach about Jesus, or if Paul will stay in prison and maybe even receive the death penalty. So Paul writes this letter to comfort Paul's dear friends in the city of Philippi. Philippi was a Roman city in eastern Macedonia, north of the sea, in a plain, a flat area of land.

Stop here and look at the map. Find Macedonia and Philippi as a group. Pause this audio here.

Paul was a teacher and friend to a young man named Timothy, who often traveled with Paul to share the good news about Jesus. Timothy is with Paul now, and even though the letter is mainly from Paul, Paul says the letter is coming from both Paul and Timothy. Timothy may be visiting Paul while Paul is in prison, or Timothy may be regularly helping Paul in Paul's ministry from prison.

Paul begins his letter by greeting all of God's holy people in Philippi who belong to Christ Jesus, including the church leaders and deacons. The deacons are people in the church who probably help the church leaders. The deacons may help by handling the money, baptizing people, serving people, and doing other things the church leaders need help with. This means that Paul is writing the letter to the people in the church in Philippi, and Paul is probably expecting everyone there who believes in Jesus to be at church and to listen to the letter together.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Give an example of someone in your culture who sends a message to someone else. How does the sender describe themselves? How does the sender describe the person or people they address the message to? Pause this audio here.

In most of the letters that Paul wrote, Paul calls himself an apostle, or someone whom God sends out with God's authority to tell the good news about Jesus. But Paul does not need to remind the Christians in Philippi of Paul's authority. The Christians in Philippi had a close relationship with Paul, and they partnered with Paul to share the gospel. The people in the church gave Paul money to pay for the cost of travel and to share with the poor people that Paul met. So Paul does not call himself an apostle in this letter. Instead, Paul calls himself and Timothy slaves of Jesus Christ.

Immediately after Paul gives the standard greeting to the people to whom Paul writes the letter, Paul talks about how grateful Paul is for the Philippians, how Paul has been praying for the Philippians, and how much Paul loves the Philippians. Paul wants the Philippians to focus on God and what God has done for the Philippians.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Can you think of a time when there was a problem that distracted you from what was more important? Give examples.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: Paul and Timothy say they are servants of Jesus and that this message is from Paul and Timothy. Paul and Timothy also say that this message is for the Christians in Philippi.

In the second part: Paul tells the Philippians that Paul has been praying for them. Paul also says how much Paul loves the Philippians and is thankful for them.

In the third part: Paul prays for the Christians in Philippi to know God even better than they already do. Paul wants the Christians in Philippi to live for God and to do the right things.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Timothy
- God our Father
- Christ Jesus
- The Christians in Philippi
- And someone who reads the letter out loud, probably Epaphroditus

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Paul and Timothy are in Rome. The Philippians are in Philippi, where they live. Epaphroditus travels from Rome to Philippi to deliver this message from Paul and Timothy to the Philippians in the church in Philippi.

In the first part of the message, Paul and Timothy greet the Philippians.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you greet people in your community? What special words or phrases do you use to greet people? What greeting do you use when you send a message to someone you know and love? Give examples. Pause this audio here.

Remember that Paul and the Philippians are all close friends, and Paul has not seen the Philippians in a long time. Paul misses the Philippians, and the Philippians miss Paul. The Philippians are worried about the fact that Paul is in prison and that Paul may receive the death penalty. Paul is also sad that people are persecuting the Philippians because the Philippians follow Jesus. Paul wants to encourage and comfort the Philippians with the truth and remind the Philippians of what Jesus has done for them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you feel when you have not seen someone you love in a long time? What would you want to say to that person? Pause this audio here.

Paul calls the believers in Philippi God's holy people, or saints. Holy people are people whom God has set apart especially to serve God. These holy people are "in" Christ Jesus. In other words, these holy people know Jesus —they serve Jesus and constantly talk with Jesus and learn from Jesus. In Paul's message to the church, Paul includes the church leaders, or overseers, and the church deacons. You will remember that the overseer of a church was the leader of the church, and the deacons helped the overseer. Paul wants everyone to hear this letter from Paul.

Philippians 1:1–11

Stop here and discuss as a group what you call the different leaders in your church. What do you call the lead pastor or pastors? What do you call the helpers, or the deacons? Pause this audio here.

Paul wishes "grace and peace" on the believers in Philippi. "Grace and peace" was a common Christian greeting during that time, and people said this greeting to each other because they wanted each other to remember that it is God and Christ Jesus who showed grace to us, and God and Christ Jesus who give us total peace. God and Christ Jesus show grace when they love us even though we do not deserve that love. God and Christ Jesus give peace, or total well-being, because they have fully restored us to God. Paul reminds the Philippians that God acts as a loving father to the Philippians when Paul calls God "the father." And Paul reminds the Philippians that Jesus is the Savior that God promised would save us and bring us this grace and peace when Paul calls Jesus "Christ."

Stop here and discuss as a group what kinds of greetings you give each other as Christians in your community. How will you translate this blessing of "grace and peace" in your translation? Pause this audio here.

In the second part of the message, Paul thanks the Philippians for their partnership in the gospel. The Philippians are partners with Paul in the work because the Philippians have agreed to work together with Paul to share the good news about Jesus, to encourage and pray for Paul, and to give money to help the mission. The Philippians have partnered with Paul "from the first day," or from the time when the Philippians first met Paul and believed in Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when people worked together to do something important. How did you describe how those people worked together for a good thing? How will you talk about the Philippians' "partnership in the gospel, or good news?" Pause this audio here.

Paul loves the Philippians, and Paul is very confident that the good work God started when God saved the Philippians, God will finish! The Philippians will continue to follow Jesus, to know Jesus and become more like Jesus, and to share Jesus with others. The Philippians will continue to do this until the "day of Christ Jesus." When Paul and other Christians talked about the "day of Christ Jesus," people understood that Jesus is coming back again someday. On this day, Jesus will reward his followers and defeat everything that is evil. Paul and the early Christians were aware that Jesus will come back one day, and the Christians lived their lives expecting that day to come.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the fact that Paul is confident that God will finish the work God started in the lives of the Philippian Christians. God will continue to work in the Christians' lives until Jesus comes back again! Pause this audio here.

Paul explains why he loves the Philippians so much. Paul says that he has the Philippians "in his heart," or that Paul loves the Philippians and thinks about the Philippians with joy. In Paul's culture, people described where they felt love and compassion as being in their heart.

Stop here and tell a story as a group about someone you love very much or are happy to know. How do you talk about your joy in being with that person? How will you say that Paul has the Philippians "in his heart?" Pause this audio here.

Paul continues to say that the Philippian Christians share in God's grace. In other words, the Philippian Christians have also chosen to follow Jesus, and God has given the Philippian Christians the gift of grace by loving them and forgiving them even though they did not deserve it. This gift of grace means that the Philippian Christians love Paul and work with him even though Paul is "in chains," or in prison. While Paul was first in prison in Rome, guards probably guarded Paul in a house. The guards probably chained Paul to a guard so that Paul would not escape. This is why Paul is "in chains."

Paul has defended, or explained, why he trusts in Jesus, and Paul has confirmed, or persuaded people, that Jesus is the promised Savior. That is why Paul is in prison. The Philippians share in Paul's suffering, either because the Philippian Christians support Paul while he is in prison, or because other people also persecute the Philippians because they follow Jesus.

Paul says that he wishes to be with the Philippian Christians and to experience their friendship again—he loves the Philippians with the same kind of love that Jesus has for them. Paul says, "God is my witness," to show how sincere and serious Paul is when he says that Paul loves the Philippians.

In the final part of this passage, Paul prays that the Philippians would focus on what really matters—that the Philippians would love and value God and love and value other people more and more. Paul prays that this deep love would come from the Philippians' knowledge of who God is—that the Philippians would really know God. Paul prays that the Philippians would also love others because the Philippians have insight, or an ability to understand what is good and right. Then the Philippians can decide how to act in the best way. The Philippians can be pure. In other words, the Philippians are not divided between evil and good—the Philippians fully follow God. Then the Philippians can be blameless, or not guilty, in front of Christ on the day when Christ Jesus comes back to judge everyone in the world. When people are pure and blameless, those people are righteous—they are in good relationship with God. This righteousness is like a wonderful fruit that only Jesus can make happen in our lives.

Stop here and, as a group, discuss how you can show that God fills people with knowledge of who God is, and with an ability to understand what is good and right. What do people like this do? How will you describe these people? How will you talk about these people being righteous, or in a right and good relationship with God? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the fact that righteousness comes "through" Christ Jesus. How is it possible for Jesus to be the one who gives us righteousness? How will you say that Jesus fills us with the fruit of righteousness? Pause this audio here.

When we have this fruit called righteousness, we have a good relationship with God. When we have this good relationship with God, we have God's love for each other. This is good news! And this good news makes us want to give glory and praise to God! When we give glory to God, we realize that God is majestic and wonderful.

Now the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:1–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Timothy
- God our Father
- Christ Jesus
- The Christians in Philippi
- And someone who reads the letter out loud, probably Epaphroditus

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Set up the drama with a person who represents Paul, and a person who represents Timothy. Have the two people in prison, praying.

Have another person, who represents Epaphroditus, carry a letter from Paul and Timothy to a group of people who represent the Philippians. Epaphroditus reads the letter to the Philippian Christians. Paul and Timothy, servants of Christ Jesus, write to the holy people, the church leaders, and the deacons in the church of Philippi. Paul and Timothy greet the Philippians with, "May God the Father and Christ Jesus give you grace and peace."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Philippians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- I am worried about Paul; or
- What is going to happen to us if Paul receives the death penalty? or
- I am so glad we finally have a message from Paul.

Continue the drama.

Paul says that Paul thanks God for the Philippians. Paul prays for the Philippians with joy because the Philippians have been good partners in the gospel from the time the Philippians first knew Paul. Paul is confident that God will continue the good work God has started until the time when Christ Jesus comes again.

It is right and good that Paul loves the Philippians because the Philippians also have received God's grace along with Paul, even as they all suffer together. God knows how much Paul loves the Philippians.

Pause the drama. Ask Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad that the Philippians are hurting; or
- I love my friends in Philippi, and I miss those friends; or
- I am so glad the Philippians love Jesus and are willing to follow Jesus even when it is hard; or
- I hope the Philippians are not too scared.

Ask the people playing the Philippians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We miss Paul too! or
- We feel good that Paul believes that God will continue to be with us.

Continue the drama.

Paul prays for the Philippians—that the Philippians will love God more and more, and that the Philippians will really know God and know what the right and good things are to do. Then the Philippians will be able to do the best things, not just the good things! The Philippians will be pure and not guilty on the day that Christ Jesus comes back to judge the world. And Christ Jesus will make the Philippians be in a good relationship with God. The Philippians can give God glory! The Philippians can praise God!

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Philippians, "What are you feeling or thinking?"

The people might answer things like:

- We love God so much! God teaches us the right things to do; or
- We praise God because God sent us Jesus. Jesus has given us a good relationship with God.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul and Timothy call themselves servants or slaves of Christ Jesus. Slaves did not have any choice but to work for their master. Paul and Timothy call themselves slaves because Paul and Timothy always work for God and

belong to God. Use a term that shows that Paul and Timothy belong to God, but make sure the term does not communicate that God is a harsh master. Christ is the same as the Messiah. Christ is the title for the King and Savior that God promised would come to save God's people.

Pause the audio here and talk about how you will say that Paul and Timothy are **slaves** of **Christ** Jesus. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same words or phrases that you have used there. For more information about slave and Christ, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Paul writes to the "saints," or holy people, in Philippi. Saints or holy people describe those who believe that Jesus is the promised Savior. These "holy people" are people whom God chose and set apart to belong to God.

Stop here and discuss what word or description you will use for **saint**, or holy people. For more information about "saint," refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for saint that you have used in translations of other books. Pause this audio here.

Paul is especially talking to the overseers and the deacons of the church in Philippi. Overseers are church leaders, who are like shepherds taking care of sheep. Overseers are responsible to make sure the people in the church have everything they need spiritually. This means overseers help the people understand the good news about Jesus and how to live for Jesus. The deacons are leaders in the church who assist the overseer. The deacons are responsible to make sure the people in the church have everything they need physically.

Stop here and discuss what word or description you will use for **overseers** and **deacons**. For more information about overseers and deacons, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Paul asks God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ to give God's saints in Philippi grace and peace. A "lord" is a master or the person who is in control of other people. When Paul calls Jesus "Lord," Paul is saying that Jesus has the same authority as God has.

If necessary, stop here and discuss what word you will use for **lord**. For more information about lord, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word for lord that you have used in other translations. Pause this audio here.

When God shows grace to someone, God is showing his favor and kindness to people who do not deserve that favor and kindness. When someone has peace, it means that person has a good relationship with God that is full of life.

Stop here and discuss what words you will use for **grace** and **peace**. Use the same words for grace and peace that you have used in previous translations. For more information about grace and peace, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

"Father" refers to our heavenly Father, who is God. Paul uses the same word for Father that you would use for your own father.

If necessary, stop here and discuss how you will talk about God as a **Father** in this book. Use the same word for God as Father that you have used in other books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

Paul prays and thanks God for the Philippians' partnership in the gospel. When someone prays to God, that person talks with God. This kind of prayer is when someone very specifically asks God for help. The gospel is the good news that Jesus died, rose again, and is with God in heaven. Jesus did this so that Jesus could save us and restore our relationship with God when we trust in Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words you will use for **pray** and **gospel**. Remember that this word for prayer specifically means to ask for help from God. For more information about pray and gospel, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases as you have used in previous translations. Pause this audio here.

Paul has the Philippians "in his heart," meaning that Paul has affection for the Philippians and is joyful when Paul thinks about the Philippians. In Paul's culture, people talked about the heart as special language for the place where people's thoughts and emotions happened.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate that Paul had the Philippians in Paul's **heart**. For more information about heart, refer to the Master Glossary. If you use the word for heart, use the same word for heart that you have used in previous translations. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that he is in chains. This means that Paul is in prison, but in that time, guards usually chained a prisoner to a guard so the prisoner could not escape. These "chains" may have been chains that people made from strong rope tied together, or they may have been metal chains.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **chains**. Remember that Paul is using the idea of chains to say that Paul is a captive and that guards guard Paul all the time. Pause this audio here.

God is a witness, or "testifies," that Paul wishes to be with the Philippians. In other words, God has seen and knows how Paul feels about the Philippians.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate that God **testifies** how Paul longs for, or wishes, to see the Philippians again. Pause this audio here.

Paul prays that the Philippians would live pure and blameless lives and that God would fill the Philippians with righteousness. If someone is pure, it means that person is clearly thinking about God—that person knows what is right and they follow it. When someone is blameless, it means nobody may accuse that person because that person has not done anything wrong. Also, if God fills a person with righteousness, it means that person has a right relationship with God, because that person has trusted in Christ Jesus. Paul tells the Philippians that Jesus is the one who fills their life with righteousness because Jesus always did the right thing, and Jesus gives us the strength to follow Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate **pure**, **blameless**, and **righteousness**. For more information about pure, blameless, and righteousness, refer to the Master Glossary. If you have translated these ideas in other parts of the Bible, use the same words here. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that this will bring "glory and praise to God." Glory has the idea of weight, or that something is very important. God's glory is God's majesty and importance.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate "This will bring much **glory** and **praise** to God." Glory and praise are in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 1:1–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (922 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Philippians 1:12–18a

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 1:12—18a and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:12—18a three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:12—18a in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Paul started this letter with Paul's normal introductions and prayer. Paul talked about how much Paul loves the Philippians and how much Paul wants the Philippians to love and know God more and love other people more and more.Paul starts this part of the letter in the same way that Paul usually starts talking about a new topic. Paul calls his audience, Paul's fellow believers, "brothers." Paul tells his fellow believers that Paul wants them to know something. Paul calls the believers brothers because God's people talked about themselves as if they were a family. God's people talked about God as their Father who adopted them, and because God adopted all of them, God's people talked about each other as if they were brothers and sisters. Even though Paul just calls the Philippians "brothers," Paul is actually talking to both the men and the women in the city of Philippi.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when do people talk about someone as family even if they are not related to that person by blood? If you do talk about someone you are really close to as family, when do you do it? If you do not talk about people in this way, how do you talk about them? Pause this audio here.

The Philippians would know that Paul was in prison in Rome. Paul tells the Philippian Christians that Jesus' good news spread further because of what had happened to Paul when the authorities put Paul in prison in Rome. Rome was the capital city of the Roman Empire. In those days, the leader, or emperor, of the Roman Empire ruled over all the countries that Paul had visited. Paul's prison was probably actually a house where Paul lived and where people could visit Paul. You will remember that the guards probably chained Paul to a soldier at all times so that Paul would not escape. This gave Paul constant ability to tell the good news about Jesus to whatever guard the soldiers had chained Paul to!

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the Roman Empire that includes the city of Rome. Pause this audio here.

Philippians 1:12–18a

Paul says that what happened to Paul advanced the gospel, or the good news about Jesus. In other words, more people heard about who Jesus was and what Jesus did. Paul probably also means that more people trust Jesus because of what happened to Paul. People would not normally expect that the good news about Jesus would spread so much when Paul was in prison. However, the palace or government officials learned that Paul was in prison because Paul preached about Christ. Perhaps Paul even preached about Christ to the palace guard!

The palace guard were the soldiers who guarded the leader, or emperor, of Rome. These soldiers sometimes also guarded other important officials. The members of the palace guard probably also did other jobs that the emperor told them to do. One of those jobs was to guard prisoners who were there to talk to the emperor. Members of the palace guard were probably guarding Paul because Paul was in Rome to talk to the emperor. There were likely several thousand soldiers in the palace guard, so Paul may have met many different guards!

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time the government put someone in prison because of that person's belief in Jesus. Who heard more about Jesus because the government put that person in prison? Pause the audio here.

Stop and discuss as a group: How do you think the conversations between Paul and the people who guarded Paul in prison went? What do you think Paul said that convinced the palace guard that Paul was there because Paul believed in Jesus? Pause this audio here.

The authorities put Paul in this prison, and when the other Christians in Rome saw this, the Lord Jesus gave these Christians confidence to tell others the good news, or "the word," about Jesus without being afraid!

Paul then says that some people are even preaching about Christ because those people are jealous and want to compete with Paul. Those people were probably jealous because Paul had a lot of authority and honor among Christians. Those people might have also been jealous because Paul had a special relationship with Jesus. Those people were also preaching about Christ because they had a bad relationship with Paul, and those people thought that preaching about Christ would create problems for Paul. Then Paul says that other people preach about Christ for right and good reasons.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: Describe someone who is doing something so that they can take respect or authority from their enemy. How do you talk about people like that differently from people who do things to help others? Pause this audio here.

Then Paul says that some people tell the message about Christ because they love people. These people know that God put Paul where Paul was so Paul could defend the gospel. When Paul defended the gospel, Paul talked about how good the message about Jesus was to everyone Paul came in contact with. This might also refer to the fact that Paul is in prison and still trusts Jesus. Other people see this and realize that they can also trust Jesus, just like Paul.

Then Paul says that the other group of people tells the message about Christ because they are selfish. These people hope that when they tell the message about Christ, it will make other people respect and like these people more than Paul. Paul says that these people do not really mean what they say when they tell people the message about Christ. Instead, these people hope to cause Paul trouble while Paul is in prison. Perhaps these people thought that Paul would be jealous that the new Christians did not hear about Jesus from Paul specifically. Or perhaps these people also spoke against Paul when they told the message about Christ.

Paul does not care if people preach the gospel for good or for bad reasons. Paul only cares that people talk about Christ, even if these people are talking about Christ for bad reasons. Paul does not care as much about whether people are talking about Christ because they love Jesus or because they hate Paul. This does not mean that Paul does not care at all about why people are telling others about Jesus. In other letters, Paul gets upset with people because they are not being sincere when they talk about Jesus. But here, Paul is not talking to people who are listening to the insincere preachers. Paul's main focus is that people are telling the gospel because Paul is in prison, even if some people who are telling the gospel do not really believe that the gospel is true. Paul rejoices because people are telling the gospel to people who do not know Jesus.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:12—18a in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Philippians 1:12–18a

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: Paul explains how Paul's imprisonment has helped more people hear the gospel.

In the second part: Paul explains how some people are telling the gospel for bad reasons and some for good reasons, but Paul is happy either way because people are telling the gospel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Jesus
- The soldiers in the palace guard
- Other people who learn that the government put Paul in prison because Paul preached the good news about Christ
- The Christian brothers and sisters Paul is writing to in Philippi
- The Christian brothers and sisters in Rome who preach Christ because they love Christ
- And the Christian brothers and sisters in Rome who preach Christ in order to cause trouble for Paul

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, Paul addresses the Philippians as "brothers." Paul calls the Philippians "brothers" because God's people talked about each other as if they were a family. God's people talked about God as their Father who adopted them. And because God adopted all of God's people, the people talked about each other as if they were brothers and sisters. Even though Paul just calls the Philippians "brothers," Paul is actually talking to both the men and the women in the city of Philippi.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul addresses the Philippians as brothers? Remember that you can say "brothers and sisters." Pause this audio here.

Paul wants the Philippians to know what has happened because Paul was in prison. Because the government put Paul in prison, more people are learning about who Christ is. Everyone in the palace guard and others have learned that Paul is in prison because Paul is following Jesus. Remember that members of the palace guard guarded the emperor, other important government officials, important prisoners, and leaders of other countries when they came to visit.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group. Do you have a special name for the group that guards the leader of your country? Do you have names for people who guard the leaders of other countries or groups? What words would you use to describe someone who did what the palace guard did? Pause the audio here.

Paul is probably using special language here. Paul does not expect the Philippians to believe that every single palace guard knows why Paul is in prison. When Paul says every palace guard knows that Paul is "in chains," or in prison, because of Christ, Paul means that many of the palace guards know that Paul is in prison because of Christ. When Paul says that Paul is "in chains for Christ," Paul means that Paul is in prison, or a prisoner in a house. You will remember that the Roman soldiers probably literally chained Paul to another guard.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that everyone knows that Paul is "in chains for Christ." Pause this audio here.

"Christ" is a word Paul uses to refer to Jesus when Paul wants to emphasize that Jesus saves people. Paul means that he is in prison because Paul was telling people about Jesus and the fact that God sent Jesus to save us. Paul might also mean that Paul is in prison because Jesus wanted Paul to be in prison so Paul could tell more people about who Jesus is.

Paul is telling people about Jesus while Paul is in prison, and the people who are helping take care of Paul while Paul is in prison are also telling people about Jesus. Paul also said that the "brothers and sisters," or other Christians in Rome, are preaching about Christ more boldly and without fear. These people can preach with

Philippians 1:12–18a

confidence in the Lord because Paul is in prison and is also preaching about Christ. Paul calls Christ Jesus "Lord" here to emphasize Jesus' authority and power.

In the second part, Paul explains that while some people are preaching for bad reasons, others are preaching for good reasons. When someone preaches, that person proclaims something with authority. First, Paul talks about people with bad motives, and then Paul talks about people with good motives. Then Paul talks about people with good motives again, and finally, Paul talks about people with bad motives again. In Paul's culture, people often put information in this order so that the audience could understand the difference between two things. In this case, Paul probably wanted to focus on the people who were preaching about Jesus for bad reasons, so Paul talked about these people first and last. But Paul did not want the Philippians to think that only people with bad motives were preaching about Jesus, so Paul also talked about people who preached about Jesus with good motives in between.

Stop and discuss this as a group: Think about a time when you really wanted to explain the difference between two groups of people. What are some ways you arrange information to make people understand the difference between the two things? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that the people who preach about Christ with bad motives are selfish—they want to look good to other people. These people do not actually want people to believe in Jesus. These people also want to cause trouble for Paul and make Paul's life in prison harder.

Then Paul asks a question: "What does it matter?" When Paul asks this question, Paul is using special language. Paul does not expect the Philippians to answer Paul's question. Instead, Paul's question shows that Paul does not think the motivation that the people have when they preach about Christ is important. Paul says that the only thing that matters is that people are telling others about Christ, and it does not matter if people do so because they really want others to know about Christ or for another reason. Paul says that Paul is celebrating because people are preaching about Christ.

Stop here and do the following activity as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone asked a question so that they could answer it themselves. Why did that person ask the question so they could answer it themselves? What is the best way to translate when Paul asks the Philippians, "What does it matter?" Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:12—18a in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Jesus
- The soldiers in the palace guard
- Other people who learn that the government put Paul in prison because Paul preached the good news about Christ
- The Christian brothers and sisters Paul is writing to in Philippi
- The Christian brothers and sisters in Rome who preach Christ because they love Christ
- And the Christian brothers and sisters in Rome who preach Christ in order to cause trouble for Paul

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

Philippians 1:12–18a

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, Paul calls the Philippians his brothers and sisters. Paul tells the Philippians that even though Paul is in prison right now, people are still telling the gospel to new people. Everyone in the palace guard and everyone else knows that Paul is in prison because Paul serves Christ.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the soldiers in the palace guard, "What are you thinking or feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I really expected Paul to be a bad person because Paul is in prison. So I was surprised to learn that Paul is actually here because Paul obeys someone called Jesus; or
- I am so glad Paul told me about Jesus, even though Paul is my prisoner; or
- I now know why Paul is in prison, but I still do not like Paul.

Continue the drama.

Paul also says that the Lord has given most of the brothers and sisters the confidence to preach about Christ even more boldly and without fear.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing all the brothers and sisters in Rome, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- If Paul is able to keep trusting in Jesus, then I can do the same thing; or
- I am not afraid to tell other people about Jesus now; or
- I love telling people about Jesus, so I am doing it as boldly as I can.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, Paul explains that some people are actually telling others the message of Christ because they are jealous or want to look better than Paul. Paul also says that some people are telling others the message of Christ for good reasons. These people do it because they love Jesus and Paul, and these people know that the government put Paul in prison so everyone could see that the gospel is true.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the brothers and sisters in Rome who preach Christ because they love Christ, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love Jesus so much that I want to tell others about Jesus; or
- Paul is in prison so that people will believe in Jesus. I should also help people believe in Jesus.

Continue the drama.

The first group, though, tells other people the message about Christ because they want more respect and want people to like them more. These people do not actually want people to know more about Jesus. These people just want Paul's life to be worse while Paul is in prison.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the brothers and sisters in Rome who preach Christ in order to cause trouble, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am really jealous of Paul, so I want Paul to suffer; or
- I am telling people about Christ, but it is only so that those people respect me more; or
- Since I am Paul's rival, I want to make Paul's life as hard as possible.

Continue the drama.

Then Paul asks what matters about the situation. And Paul's answer is that the only thing that matters is that people tell others about Jesus. It does not matter whether people tell others about Jesus for good reasons or bad ones. Paul says he is happy that people are preaching Christ.

Philippians 1:12–18a

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy that people are telling others about Jesus; or
- Even though there are a lot of bad things happening right now, the important thing is that people are talking about Jesus.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:12—18a in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul calls the Philippians “brothers.” Even though Paul calls the Philippians brothers, Paul is talking to both the men and women who believe in Jesus in the city of Philippi.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **brothers**, or “brothers and sisters.” If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the brothers and sisters that what happened to Paul actually helped people hear the **gospel**, or “good news.” The gospel is the message about Jesus that Paul and others told to people. Use the same term for gospel that you used in the previous passage. For more information on gospel, refer to the Master Glossary.

All the soldiers in the palace guard and everyone else knew that Paul was in **chains**, or prison, for **Christ**. The word Christ refers to the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. Use the same phrase for “in chains for Christ” that you used in the previous passage. For more information on Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **palace guard**, or the group of soldiers that guarded people in the palace and in the prison. Pause this audio here.

Because Paul was in prison, the **Lord**, or Jesus, gave the brothers and sisters confidence. When, after the resurrection of Jesus, people talk about Jesus and call him “Lord,” they are saying that Jesus has authority over those people, just as God has. When people call Jesus “Lord” after his resurrection, those people are saying that Jesus is God. Look up lord in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word that you have used previously.

The brothers and sisters have the confidence to speak God’s “word,” or message, more boldly and without fear. When people in the New Testament talk about “the word,” “the word of God,” or “the word of the Lord,” those people usually mean the good news that Jesus has come into the world.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **word**. Look up word in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that some people preach about Christ because of jealousy and rivalry. When someone preaches, that person speaks with authority about a subject. “Jealousy” means that these people want the respect and honor that Paul has, and “rivalry” means that these people are working against Paul.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **preach**, **jealousy**, and **rivalry**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Others preach about Christ for good reasons. These people preach about Christ because they love God and they love people. Use the same word for love that you used in the previous passage. These people know that the government put Paul in prison so that Paul could argue that the gospel is true. When people put someone in prison, they make that person stay in a room or building. Those people do not allow the person to leave this room or building.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **prison**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The first people tell people the message about Christ because of selfish ambition. This means that these people just want to get more respect, and these people want other people to like them more. These people are not sincere, which means these people do not actually want people to know more about Christ. Instead, these people want to make Paul's life worse while Paul is in prison.

Paul asks, "So what?" Then Paul answers his own question: it is only important that someone proclaims the good news about Christ, whether it is because those people have false motives or honest motives. Paul says that he rejoices in that. "Rejoicing" means that Paul celebrates and gets happy about people talking about Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **rejoice**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 1:12–18a

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (926 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Philippians 1:18b–26

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 1:18b—26 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:18b—26 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:18b—26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Remember that before this, Paul had greeted the Philippian church and told the people there that Paul was praying for them and rejoicing because the Philippians loved God and people so much. Then Paul told the Philippians about what Paul was experiencing. Even though some people who were telling others the message about Christ were doing it for bad reasons, Paul was still happy that people were talking about Jesus.

In this passage, Paul says that he will continue to rejoice. Paul knows that the Philippians are praying for Paul and that Jesus' Spirit is helping Paul, so Paul is joyful. Jesus's "Spirit" is another way to talk about the Holy Spirit. Paul also calls Jesus "Christ." Paul refers to Jesus as Christ when Paul wants people to think about how God sent Jesus to save us. Paul knows that Jesus' Spirit will rescue Paul because the Philippians are praying for Paul. When Paul says that Jesus will rescue Paul, Paul probably means that Jesus will get Paul out of prison. Paul also might mean that Jesus will save Paul from sin and death when Jesus comes back again to judge the people in the world.

Paul eagerly expects and hopes that Paul will not experience shame in any way. Paul might mean that Paul hopes God or other people will not shame Paul. But Paul probably means that Paul hopes Paul will not do anything that would shame God.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: What are some things in your society that would cause people to be ashamed? What do you think would cause people or God to shame someone? Pause this audio here.

Paul expects that instead of being ashamed, Paul will have enough courage so that Paul will "exalt," or honor, Christ in Paul's body. When Paul says Paul's "body," Paul probably means all of himself, including Paul's body, spirit, and mind. What happens in Paul's body could cause people to honor Christ. Paul wants people to respect Christ more and love Christ more, so Paul wants to honor Christ whether Paul lives or dies. Paul says that if Paul lives, Paul can keep telling people about Christ, and if Paul dies, God will reward Paul because Paul told people about Christ.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: Tell a story about a person who lives in such a way that other people who know this person want to know God or praise God more. What things does that person do that make other people respect that person or a god or spirit connected to that person? Pause this audio here.

If Paul continues to live in his body, that will mean that the work Paul does for Christ will be "fruitful," or produce good results. Since Christians believe that we will come back to life after we die and God will give us a new body, Paul specifies that Paul is talking about living in the body Paul currently has.

But Paul does not know what he will choose. Paul is talking about choosing between life and death. Paul probably means that Paul does not know whether Paul is going to try to get the Roman emperor to let Paul live or not. Paul is struggling to decide if Paul wants to live or if Paul will be happy if the emperor kills Paul. Paul wants to die, or to leave this world and be with Christ. Jews and Christians believed that when a person dies, that person's spirit leaves their body. Paul is saying that Paul wants to die so that Paul's spirit can leave his body and be with Christ. Paul thinks dying would be a lot better than living. Paul knows that dying would be better than living because Paul will get to have a closer relationship with God and not have any pain once Paul dies.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What does your culture believe about death? What do people in your culture think happens to your relationship to God when you die? Pause this audio here.

However, Paul thinks that the Philippians need Paul to remain in his body, or alive, more than Paul would like to die. Paul probably also means that the Christians in the world at that time need Paul to remain alive. Paul is a leader in the church of that time, and Paul does a lot of work for the Christians in the churches around the world. Paul is confident that these Christians need Paul to stay alive, so Paul knows that Paul will remain, or stay, alive. Paul will remain with the Philippians so that they can have more and more joy as the Philippians trust in Jesus more and more. That means that while Paul talks to the Philippians and helps them, Paul will help the Philippians to trust and follow Christ Jesus even more and also be more joyful because they have faith in, or trust Jesus for all parts of their life. Because Paul will be with the Philippians, the Philippians will boast more and more about Christ Jesus. When the Philippians boast about Christ Jesus, the Philippians talk about how amazing Jesus is and how all the good things the Philippians do are because of Jesus.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some things that people in your culture are proud of? What things do people in your culture boast about?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:18b—26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: Paul tells the Philippians that he knows Christ will rescue Paul and that Paul will honor Christ in Paul's body.

In the second part: Paul explains to the Philippians that Paul is struggling with whether Paul wants to live or die, but Paul is confident that Paul will keep living for the Philippians' sake.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Jesus Christ
- The Spirit of Jesus Christ
- And the Philippian Christians

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that before this, Paul had greeted the Philippian church and told them that Paul was praying for them and rejoicing because they loved God and people so much. Then Paul told the Philippians about what Paul was experiencing. Even though some people who were telling others the message about Christ were doing so for bad reasons, Paul says he rejoices that people are talking about Jesus.

In the first part of this passage, Paul says that he will continue to rejoice. Paul repeats that he will rejoice because Paul wants the Philippians to see how happy and confident Paul is that Jesus will take care of Paul. Paul even starts his statement with "yes!" so that the Christians in Philippians know that Paul really means that he is happy even though Paul is in prison.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people emphasize information in your culture, especially information that might surprise people? What is the best way to translate when Paul says that, yes, Paul will even continue to rejoice? Pause this audio here.

Paul knows that the Philippians are praying for Paul and that Jesus Christ's Spirit is helping Paul, so Paul is happy. Jesus Christ's Spirit is another way to talk about the Holy Spirit. Paul also calls Jesus "Christ." Remember that Paul refers to Jesus as Christ when Paul wants people to think about how God sent Jesus to save us. Paul knows that Jesus's Spirit will rescue Paul because the Philippians are praying for Paul. When Paul says that Jesus will rescue him, Paul probably means that Jesus will get Paul out of prison. Paul also might mean that Jesus will

Philippians 1:18b–26

save Paul from sin and death when Jesus comes back again to judge the world. However, Paul talks later about expecting to see the Philippians again, so Paul probably mostly means that Jesus will rescue Paul from prison.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate that Jesus will rescue Paul because the Philippians are praying for Paul, and because Jesus Christ's Spirit helps Paul? Pause this audio here.

Paul eagerly expects and hopes that Paul will not experience shame in any way. When a person eagerly expects and hopes that something will happen, that person feels confident that the thing will happen. The person also acts in a way that shows they expect the thing to happen. Paul is confident and expects that Paul will not experience shame.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate that Paul eagerly expects and hopes that Paul will not experience shame? Pause this audio here.

Paul probably means that Paul will not do anything that would shame God. Paul wanted to represent God well, even though people thought less of Paul and shamed Paul while Paul was in prison.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time people shamed someone, but later someone showed that the person was actually doing a good thing or was a good person. Now tell a story about a time when someone tried to act in a way that would not bring shame to someone else. What words did you use to talk about shaming other people? What is the best way to translate that Paul eagerly expects that Paul will not experience shame? Pause this audio here.

Paul expects that instead of Paul experiencing shame, Paul will have enough courage so that Paul will exalt, or honor, Christ in Paul's body. When Paul says Paul's body, Paul is using special language to mean all of himself, including his body and his spirit and his mind. Paul says that everything Paul says and does will cause people to recognize that Christ is great.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says that Paul will honor Christ in Paul's body? Pause this audio here.

Paul wants to honor Christ whether Paul lives or dies. Paul thinks that to live is Christ and to die is gain. Paul uses special language here. Paul uses as few words as possible when he says this because Paul wants people to think carefully about what Paul means. Paul means that if Paul lives, Paul can keep telling people about Christ, and if Paul dies, God will reward Paul because Paul told people about Christ. Whether Paul lives or dies, good things happen to Paul!

Stop here and discuss as a group: Give some examples of short, positive statements that have important meanings in your culture. What tone of voice do you use when you say these statements? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What is the best way for you to translate when Paul says that to live is Christ and to die is gain? Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul explains Paul's short but important statement. If Paul lives in the body, or remains alive, that will mean fruitful work for Paul. Since Christians believe that we will come back to life after we die and get a new body, Paul needs to be clear that Paul is talking about while Paul lives in the body he currently has. When Paul talks about fruitful work, Paul is using special language. Just as a healthy fruit tree gives fruit, people who work hard see the good results of their work. Paul wants to see the good results of Paul's work for Christ. What is Paul's work for Christ? Paul tells the message of Christ's good news to people so that people follow Christ.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What is the best way to translate how Paul says that if Paul lives, Paul will be able to do work that produces good fruit, or good results? Pause this audio here.

Paul does not know what Paul will choose. Paul is talking about choosing between life and death. Paul probably means that Paul does not know whether Paul is going to try to get the Roman emperor to let Paul live or not. The two options are pressing against Paul. When Paul says that the two options are pressing against him, Paul is using special language to mean that Paul is struggling to choose between the two options.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time that you were struggling to decide between two options. Pay attention to how you describe the struggle. What is the best way to translate when Paul says that the two options are pressing against Paul? Pause this audio here.

Philippians 1:18b–26

Paul wants to leave and be with Christ. Paul talks about leaving because Jews and Christians believed that when a person dies, that person's spirit leaves that person's body. The spirit is the invisible part of a person, and sometimes people talk about the spirit as the inner part of a person. When someone who believes in Jesus dies, that person's spirit will continue to live with God. Paul is saying that Paul wants to die so that Paul can be with Christ.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says that Paul wants to leave and be with Christ? Pause this audio here.

Paul thinks dying would be a lot better than living because Paul will get to have a closer relationship with God and not have any pain once Paul dies. However, Paul thinks that the Philippians need Paul to remain in his body, or be alive, more than Paul would like to die. Notice that Paul talks about "remaining" in his body when Paul talks about being alive, and Paul talks about "leaving" his body when Paul talks about dying.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says that Paul will remain in the body? Pause this audio here.

Paul will remain with the Philippians so that they can have more and more joy as they trust in Jesus more and more. That means that while Paul talks to the Philippian Christians and helps them, Paul will help the Christians progress in their faith and also be more joyful in their faith. The Philippians progress in their faith or trust in Jesus as they become more like Jesus. This means that the Philippians are obeying more and more the things that Jesus has told them to do. The Philippians also experience joy because God gives them joy as the Philippians obey Jesus and become more like Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What is the best way to translate Paul's desires for the Philippians to have progress and joy in the faith? Pause this audio here.

Because Paul will be with the Philippians, the Philippians will boast more and more about Christ Jesus. When someone boasts about someone else, that person talks about how amazing the other person is. That person has confidence in the other person. Paul says that boasting about Jesus and the things Jesus does is a good thing! When the Philippians boast, they are praising Christ Jesus because Jesus has brought Paul back to the Philippians.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time someone was boasting about a person or thing. What would be the best way to translate that the Philippians will boast more and more about Christ Jesus because of what happens to Paul? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:18b—26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Jesus Christ
- The Spirit of Jesus Christ
- And the Philippian Christians

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

Philippians 1:18b–26

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Paul tells the Philippians that Paul will continue to rejoice because the Philippians are praying for Paul, and Jesus Christ's Spirit is helping Paul. Therefore, Jesus will save Paul.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jesus's Spirit, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am helping Paul because I know that Paul can still do good things for me; or
- I love Paul, and I want Paul to be okay; or
- I am going to save Paul from this situation.

Continue the drama.

Paul says that Paul eagerly expects everything to happen well and Paul hopes that Paul will not feel any shame in any way. Instead, Paul wants to have enough courage to honor Christ with Paul's body, whether Paul lives or dies.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really want to be able to honor Christ no matter what happens to me; or
- No one can shame me in any way because Christ is proud of what I am doing for Christ; or
- I hope Jesus gives me the courage I need to keep showing other people how amazing Christ is.

Continue the drama.

Then Paul says that the reason he says "whether he lives or dies" is because, for Paul, to live is Christ and to die is gain. Paul explains that if Paul keeps living in the body, Paul will continue to do meaningful work. Paul does not know what he will choose. Paul is torn between the two options: Paul wants to leave and go be with Christ, which is the much better option for Paul. However, the Philippians need Paul to stay more than Paul needs to leave. Paul is convinced that this is true, so Paul knows he will remain with the Philippians. Paul will do this to help the Philippians progress in their trust in Christ and their joy in their trust in Christ. And then Paul's presence will cause the Philippians to boast more and more in Christ because of Paul.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philippian Christians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that Paul is still alive to help us become better Christians; or
- I am so happy because I trust in Jesus; or
- Paul showed me how amazing Jesus is, and I am going to tell everyone about Jesus.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:18b—26 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul says that Paul will continue to **rejoice**. Use the same word or phrase for rejoice that you used in previous passages.

Paul says that Paul knows that Jesus will rescue, or "save," Paul. If you save someone, you rescue that person from a difficult or dangerous situation. The danger can be physical or spiritual.

Philippians 1:18b–26

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **save**. Look up **salvation** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jesus will rescue Paul through the Philippians' **prayers**. When you pray, or offer a prayer, you are communicating with God. You might be praising God, thanking God, asking God for help, telling God about the wrong things you have done, asking God to help other people, or you might just be crying to God because you feel so sad. In the Bible, all these things are part of praying. In this case, these prayers are asking God for help. Use the same word or phrase for prayer that you used in Philippians 1:4. For more information on prayer, refer to the Master Glossary

Jesus will also rescue Paul through the help of Jesus **Christ's** "Spirit." The Holy Spirit is the Spirit of God. Sometimes the Bible calls this the "Spirit of God," the "Spirit of Jesus," the "Spirit of the Lord," or sometimes just "the Spirit." The word "Christ" refers to the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. Use the same word for Christ that you used in previous passages. For more information on Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Jesus Christ's Spirit**. Look up **Holy Spirit** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul eagerly expects and hopes that Paul will not shame himself. Hope is the confident expectation that something will happen. When you hope for something, you expect that it will happen.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **hope**. Look up hope in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul wants to exalt, or praise, Christ in Paul's body. In this case, Paul's body refers to everything about Paul—his spirit, mind, and physical body.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for Paul's **body** when it talks about Paul's whole self. Pause this audio here.

Paul believes that if Paul continues to live in his body, Paul will see good results from Paul's work for Christ. In this case, Paul's body refers to Paul's physical body.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for Paul's physical body. Pause this audio here.

Paul knows that Paul will stay alive and stay with the Philippians, so that the Philippians can have more progress and joy in the faith, or trust in Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **faith**. Look up faith in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 1:18b–26

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (927 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Philippians 1:27–30

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 1:27—30 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:27—30 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:27—30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the beginning of Paul's letter to the church in Philippi, Paul explained what was happening to Paul. Paul explained that more people were hearing the gospel because the authorities had put Paul in prison, and that Paul was sure that he would survive so that Paul could keep helping the Philippian church.

In this passage, Paul gives the Philippians a command. Paul wants the people in the church to pay attention because Paul is about to say something really important. Paul wants the Philippian believers to be good citizens of God's Kingdom by acting in a good way. Just like a person is a good citizen of a kingdom when they act in the way the king tells them to act, Paul is telling the Philippians to be worthy of being followers of Christ, or act in the way Christ told Christ's followers to act. This will make Christ proud. We will see in this passage that the Philippians show people that the message they are telling people about Christ is true by the way they live their lives with love and peace.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: What kinds of things do good citizens of your country do? How do people show that they are good citizens of a country? Pause this audio here.

Philippians 1:27–30

Paul knows that he might die before Paul gets a chance to go to the city of Philippi and see the Philippian Christians. Paul wants the Philippian Christians to be good citizens of God's Kingdom so that, whether Paul comes to see the Philippians or cannot come to see them, Paul will hear about how the Philippians stand firm in one spirit. When someone "stands firm in one spirit," that person continues to do the right things even though people try to make that person do the wrong things. But the Philippians will not try to stand firm on their own. Instead, the Philippians will be united and work together to help each other continue to obey Jesus. Paul also says the Philippians will strive together as one for the faith. In other words, the Philippians will work hard together and help each other to trust Jesus more and more because of the truth about Jesus that they have heard in the gospel message. Paul tells the Philippians not to let the people who oppose the Christians frighten them. The people who opposed the Philippian Christians were probably people who worshiped the Roman gods and also worshiped the emperor as a god. These opponents would have been upset because they thought that if the Philippian Christians did not worship the Roman gods and the emperor, those gods would get mad and punish everyone in Philippi. These opponents were trying to make the Philippian Christians worship the Roman gods.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: What sort of opposition is there in your culture against people who want to totally devote themselves to Jesus? How is this opposition different from and similar to what the Philippians probably had to deal with? Pause this audio here.

Paul probably says that if the Philippian believers are not frightened and continue to obey Jesus, the believers' courage will be a sign to their opponents that God will destroy the opponents. When the Philippians do the right thing in any circumstance, it will show their opponents that God will destroy the opponents but save the Philippian Christians. God saves the Christians when God gives them the gift of living with God forever. God destroys the Christians' opponents by not giving those people the gift of living with God forever.

God has given the Philippians grace, or the great gift that they can both trust in Christ and suffer for Christ. You might be surprised that Paul said it is a gift to suffer for Christ! However, when Christians suffer because they trust in Jesus, those Christians honor Jesus. And God honors the Christians who suffer! This is a great privilege to be worthy enough to suffer for someone else! Paul tells the Philippian Christians that they do not deserve to trust Jesus or to suffer for Jesus, but Jesus allows the Christians to trust Jesus and to suffer for him anyway. We will hear in later passages how suffering for Jesus is a true gift because suffering can help us be closer to Jesus.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when a person loved an important person so much that they suffered in place of, or instead of, that person. How did the person who chose to suffer feel about suffering for the important person? How did the important person honor the person who chose to suffer for the important person? Pause this audio here.

Paul reminds the Philippians that Paul struggled in Philippi also. As you will remember, the Philippian authorities beat Paul and put him in prison because Paul was telling people about Jesus. Paul reminds the Philippians that now, through this letter to their church, the Philippians hear that Paul is still struggling even now! Paul is encouraging the Philippian Christians that they are suffering together for Jesus!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:27–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians to be good citizens who stand firm and do not let their opponents make them afraid.

In the second part: Paul says that when the Philippian Christians suffer, it will be a sign that God will destroy their opponents but that God will save the Philippian Christians, since their suffering is a gift from God.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul

- Christ
- God, the Father
- The Philippian Christians
- And the opponents of the Philippian Christians

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that Paul has just been talking about how more people are hearing the gospel because Paul is in prison, and that Paul is confident that Paul will keep living so he can help the Philippian Christians. The big idea in this part of Paul's letter is that the believers in Philippi should act like good citizens, or people who are worthy to follow Jesus Christ as their Savior. Everything else Paul says in this part of his letter connects to the idea of behaving well as good citizens.

In the previous passage, Paul talked about how he might die, so now Paul wants the Philippians to know that no matter what happens to Paul, Paul will hear about what the Philippians are doing. In the first part of this passage, Paul tells the Philippian Christians that the most important thing for them to do is to be good citizens who are worthy of the gospel of Christ. Paul explains that if the Philippians do that, then whether Paul comes to see the Philippian Christians or only hears about them, Paul will know that the Philippians are standing firm in one spirit. Paul is talking about things that could happen. Paul is not saying that these things will happen; Paul is saying that if the Philippians are good citizens, then Paul will either see or hear about how the Philippians are standing firm.Stop here and discuss this as a group: How do you talk about things that might happen? How do you talk about what things will happen if someone does what you are telling that person to do? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that if the Philippian believers truly act in a way that shows they are citizens in God's kingdom, then Paul will hear good things about the Philippians. Paul will hear that the Philippians are standing firm in one spirit. When someone "stands firm," that person continues to do the right things even though people try to make them do the wrong things.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have two people stand side by side. One person should work hard to stand up straight, even as the second person pushes hard against that person and tries to make them move. This is like Paul telling the Philippian Christians to stand firm, even when people try to make them do wrong things. How will you talk about standing firm? Pause this audio here.

When the believers have one spirit, the believers have the same purpose. A person's spirit usually refers to the inner part of a person where their thoughts and emotions are. In this case, the Christians all want to work together to obey Christ! The Christians work hard together to follow Christ more.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about believers who stand firm in "one spirit"? Pause this audio here.

Paul also says the Philippians will strive or fight together to trust and obey Christ more and more because they believe the truth of the good news about Christ. Sometimes it is hard to always trust and obey Christ! So the Philippians will work very hard together and help each other to trust and obey Christ more and more.

In the second part of this passage, Paul tells the Philippian Christians that when they are not frightened and trust Christ, it will be a sign or demonstration to their opponents that God will destroy their opponents and save the Philippian Christians. The sign will work because God gave the Philippian Christians the grace, or opportunity, to both trust in Christ and also to suffer or experience persecution because they follow Christ.

The Philippian Christians also have the same struggle that they saw Paul had and are now hearing that Paul still has. When people struggle, it is like they are fighting against an enemy. Here, Paul's struggle is the opposition that he has because Paul trusts Christ. Paul's opponents have put Paul in prison because Paul preached the good news of Jesus. The Philippian Christians are also struggling with people opposing them because they trust Christ.

Stop and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone had a conflict with others because of something they were doing. How will you describe how Paul struggled, and now how the Philippians are struggling? Pause this audio here.

Philippians 1:27–30

Paul says that the Philippian Christians' faith right now shows their opponents that in the future God will destroy the opponents and will save the Philippian Christians. Then Paul talks about the past when Paul says that God gave the Philippians the grace not just to believe in Christ but also to suffer for Christ. God gave the Philippians this grace before Paul wrote the letter to them. The Philippian Christians also saw Paul suffering when he was with them in Philippi, even before Paul wrote this letter. Then Paul talks about the present again when Paul says that they now hear that Paul is still suffering. Paul is telling the Philippian Christians in this letter that Paul is still struggling.

Stop and discuss this as a group: How do you talk about things that happened in the past? How do you talk about things that will happen in the future? What kinds of things can happen to you in the past, even right now, and in the future? If you wanted to talk about things that happened in the past, are happening in the present, and will happen in the future, what are some ways you would do that? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:27—30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Christ
- God, the Father
- The Philippian Christians
- And the opponents of the Philippian Christians

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that they should act like good citizens of God's kingdom who are worthy of the gospel of Christ. If the Philippian Christians do this, then Paul will hear that they are standing firm in one spirit. Paul will hear this whether Paul is with the Philippians or away from them. While the Philippians are standing firm, they will be striving together with one mind for the faith of the gospel, and the Philippians will not let their opponents make them afraid.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philippian Christian, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am not afraid of the people who are trying to stop us from being Christian; or
- I am so glad that all the other Christians in Philippi are helping me show people how amazing Jesus is; or
- I am glad that Paul is proud of us for being good citizens of God's kingdom.

Continue the drama

Philippians 1:27–30

Paul tells the Philippians that this will show their opponents that God will destroy the opponents and save the Philippian Christians.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the opponents of the Philippian Christians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am really scared because God will destroy us; or
- The Philippian Christians are trying to show us that God will destroy us, but I do not believe them; or
- Why are the Philippian Christians not scared of us? Something must be going on that we do not understand.

Continue the drama

The Philippian Christians will show their opponents that God will destroy the opponents because God gave them the grace to not just believe Jesus but also to suffer for Jesus's sake. The Philippian Christians are dealing with the same struggle that they saw Paul had, and the same struggle that Paul is now telling the Philippians he still has.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really want the Philippian Christians to keep obeying Jesus; or
- I love the Philippian Christians and am so proud of what they are doing for Jesus; or
- I am really struggling with a lot of things right now, but I am happy to struggle for the sake of Jesus.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 1:27–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that the most important thing for them to do is to live as citizens who are worthy of the **gospel**, or good news, that they are telling people about **Christ**. Look up gospel and Christ in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same words or phrases for gospel and Christ as you used in previous passages.

Paul says that he will see that the Philippian Christians are standing firm in one spirit. This is probably not the Holy Spirit. Instead, this spirit refers to the Philippians' strong desire to work together.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that the Philippians are standing firm in one **spirit**. Refer to spirit in the Master Glossary for more information, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that they are fighting for the **faith** of the gospel. Look up faith in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same word or phrase for faith as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that the Philippians are fighting for the **faith of the gospel**. Remember that the "faith of the gospel" is the way that the Philippians trust Christ because of the gospel message. Pause this audio here.

When the Philippian Christians are not frightened, it will be a sign to their opponents, or show their opponents, that God will destroy the opponents and God will save the Philippian Christians. Although God saving the Christians could refer to either physical or spiritual salvation, in this case, it probably refers to spiritual salvation. Look up **salvation** in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word or phrase for saves, or salvation, as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that the Christians' actions will be a **sign** to their opponents. Pause this audio here.

God has given the Philippian Christians a special **grace**, or privilege. God gives grace when he gives people a good gift that they do not deserve. Look up grace in the Master Glossary for more information. The Philippian Christians have the grace not just to "believe," or trust, in Christ but also to suffer for Christ.

Philippians 1:27–30

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the idea of **believing** in Christ. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about **belief**. Pause this audio here.

When someone suffers, they feel pain or experience something really bad. In this case, people may suffer harm from others because those people are telling the good news about Jesus to others.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe the idea of someone **suffering**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul explains that they are struggling with the same thing they saw Paul struggle with, and are now hearing that Paul is still struggling with. When someone struggles, that person has a conflict with someone or something else. This conflict can be physical, or this conflict can be personal. In this case, Paul has many opponents who have put Paul in prison because Paul was preaching the good news. When Paul says the Philippians are struggling, Paul means the Philippians are obeying Jesus even though people are trying to get the Philippians to stop obeying Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe Paul's and the Philippian Christians' **struggle**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 1:27–30

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (917 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Philippians 2:1–4

Philippians 2:1–4

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 2:1—4 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:1—4 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:1—4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last passage, Paul explained that the most important thing for the Philippian Christians to do was to live as good citizens of God's kingdom. Paul also explained how the Philippians should be good citizens, and Paul explained that God gave the Philippians the privilege to suffer for Christ.

In this passage, Paul asks the Philippian Christians to make Paul even more joyful. Paul reminds the Philippians that these things are true about their relationship with God and each other: Christ encourages the Philippians or makes them strong because they completely follow Christ, God comforts the Philippians because God loves them, the Philippian Christians have a good relationship with the Spirit, and the Philippian Christians care about people who are in need and sympathize with them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some of the things that people in your culture expect God or gods or spirits to do for those people? How does that compare with what Paul says God does for the Philippian Christians? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that since God has done all of these things for the Philippian Christians, the Philippians can and should make Paul's joy complete. Paul already told the Philippian Christians that Paul had joy because of what the Philippians were doing. Now, when Paul tells the Philippians to make his joy complete, Paul means he wants the Philippians to make Paul as joyful as he could possibly be.

The Philippians' good relationship with God makes them able to become even more unified with each other. Paul uses his close relationship with the Philippians to encourage them to be more unified. Paul does this by saying that the Philippians will make Paul even happier if they are unified! Paul wants the Philippian Christians to agree with each other about what they think about Jesus and how to obey Jesus together. Paul also wants the Philippians to have the same love. In other words, Paul wants the Philippians to love each other. Paul also wants the Philippians to have one spirit. That means Paul wants the Philippians to work together gladly to obey Jesus. Paul also wants the Philippians to think one thing. This is very similar to when Paul said he wanted the Philippians to agree about things. Paul means the Philippians need to agree with each other about the important things they do when they follow Jesus. You will remember earlier that Paul told the Philippians that they should strive, or work hard together, to obey Christ Jesus well. Now Paul reminds the Philippians that they need to have one spirit and one mind so that they can do that!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time people in your culture disagreed with each other. How do you know when a disagreement is serious or not? In a family or a group of people, what is important for people to agree on? Pause this audio here.

Now Paul begins to address some issues that Paul realizes are happening in the Philippian church. Paul says that the Philippian Christians should not do things pridefully or selfishly. Instead, Paul wants the Philippians to treat

Philippians 2:1–4

other people like those people are more important than themselves. In other words, Paul wants the Philippians to treat each other with humility. Paul also wants the Philippians to not just take care of themselves, but also take care of each other. Some translations say Paul does not want the Philippian Christians to value their own interests, but value the interests of others more.

If the Philippian Christians do these things, then Paul's joy will be complete.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, who are people supposed to take care of? Why should people take care of those people?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:1—4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: Paul gives a list of things that are true of the Philippian Christians.

In the second part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians additional things they can do to make Paul's joy complete.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Christ
- The Spirit
- God, the Father
- And the Philippian Christians

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The most important part of the passage is when Paul tells the Philippians to make Paul's joy complete. In the first part, Paul tells the Philippians things that are true about their relationship with God, and in the second part, Paul tells the Philippians what they should do to make Paul's joy complete.

In the first part, Paul states four things that are true about the Philippian Christians. First, Paul says that the Philippians' life in Christ brings them encouragement. In other words, Christ has encouraged or made the Philippian Christians strong because they allow Christ to totally control and guide their lives. Second, God's or Christ's love comforts the Philippians, or causes them not to worry about their life. In other words, when the Philippians know that God, or Christ, loves them, the Philippians do not worry so much. Third, the Holy Spirit has fellowship, or a relationship, with the Philippians. In other words, the Philippians know and talk with the Holy Spirit and the Holy Spirit guides and comforts the Philippians like a friend. Fourth, the Philippians have compassion and sympathy for each other. These things are true, and Paul knows these things are true. Paul wants the Philippian Christians to think about all the things God does for the Philippians so that they will want to do what Paul is asking the Philippians to do.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time someone needed to convince people to do something. What reasons did that person give for why people should do that thing? How would you remind people of things that they know and that are reasons why they should listen to you? Pause this audio here.

In the second part, Paul tells the Philippian Christians to make Paul even more joyful. Paul says the Philippians should make Paul's joy complete, or full, like a person fills up a container with good things until it is completely full!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture talk about joy? How do people talk about making someone more joyful? Pause this audio here.

Paul wants the Philippians to do several things with each other that will make Paul more joyful. The first thing Paul asks the Philippians to do with each other follows on from the first thing Paul tells the Philippians is true

about their relationship with Christ! Just like Christ encourages the Philippians because they completely follow Christ, Paul wants the Philippian Christians to "have the same mind" with each other about following Christ. In other words, Paul wants the Philippians to agree with each other about what they think about Christ Jesus and how to obey Jesus together.

Stop here and discuss as a group about a time when two people or groups of people decided together to think about something in the same way and to do something in the same way. How do you talk about that? How will you translate that the Philippians should have the "same mind"? Pause this audio here.

Just as God the Father and Christ love the Philippians, Paul also wants the Philippians to love each other.

Finally, just as it is true that the Philippians have a good relationship with the Holy Spirit, Paul wants the Philippians to have one spirit and one mind with each other. In other words, the Philippians should agree with each other and work with each other gladly and well, for a common purpose.

Stop here and discuss as a group about a time when two people or groups of people worked together gladly and well. How did you describe that relationship? How will you say that the Philippians should have one spirit and one mind? Pause this audio here.

Now Paul addresses what may be going wrong in the Philippian church. Paul does not want selfish ambition or pride to motivate what the Philippian Christians do. Instead, Paul wants the Philippians to humbly consider other people more important than themselves. Paul also does not want the Philippians to only take care of themselves; Paul also wants the Philippians to take care of each other. All of the things Paul wants the Philippians to do will make Paul's joy complete.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Here, Paul talks about something that the Philippian Christians should not do. How will you change the tone of the passage from all the things the Philippians should do to talking about the things the Philippians should not do? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:1—4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Christ
- The Spirit
- God, the Father
- And the Philippian Christians

Note that many of the actions in this passage are things the Philippian Christians do to each other, so it is a good idea to have multiple people playing Philippian Christians.

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Philippians 2:1–4

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Paul starts listing things that are true for the Philippian Christians. Paul says that if the Philippians have encouragement from Christ, if God's love comforts the Philippians, and if the Spirit has a relationship with the Philippians, then the Philippians should make Paul's joy complete. Paul is trying to get the Philippian Christians to think about these truths in their lives.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philippian Christians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so grateful for all the things God has done for me; or
- I have so much comfort from what Jesus is doing for me; or
- I am so glad I have a relationship with God.

Ask the person playing the Spirit, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy to be with and help out the Philippian Christians; or
- I want to have a really close relationship with the Philippian Christians.

Continue the drama.

Paul also says that if the Philippians have any sympathy or compassion for each other, then the Philippians must make Paul's joy complete by doing several things Paul wants them to do. Paul lists all these things because Paul wants the Philippians to agree with each other about important things, love each other, and think the same things and have the same spirit as each other.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the Philippian Christians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy because all the other Christians are helping me obey Jesus; or
- It is hard to agree with all the other Philippian Christians, but I want to make Paul happy, so I am going to do it; or
- I love all the Christians at Philippi.

Continue the drama.

Paul does not want the Philippian Christians to let selfish ambition or pride motivate them. Instead, Paul wants the Philippians to humbly consider other people more important than they are. Paul also wants the Philippians to take care of each other instead of just each person taking care of themselves.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am really joyful because the Philippian Christians are doing such a good job obeying Christ and working together; or
- I love how humble and unified the Philippian Christians are; or
- I am so happy that the Philippian Christians are taking care of each other.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:1—4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul says Christ gives the Philippian Christians encouragement. When someone encourages another person, they support that person and help that person accomplish what the person is trying to do. They often talk to the person they are encouraging and explain what is good about that person, or they explain that the situation is not as bad as the person thinks it is.

Philippians 2:1–4

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe that Christ **encourages** the Philippian Christians. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The encouragement is in Christ. Paul calls Jesus by the title of **Christ** when Paul wants people to think about how God sent Jesus to save us. Use the same word or phrase for Christ as you used in previous passages. For more information on Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul says there is comfort from **love**. Love in this context means the love that God had for the Philippians. When God saved the Philippian Christians from the guilt of their sins, God was loving them. When God helped the Philippian Christians become better people and have better lives, God was loving them. Use the same word or phrase for love as you have used in previous passages.

Paul says there is fellowship, or a good relationship, with the Spirit. Here, Paul is talking about the **Holy Spirit**, even though Paul just calls it the Spirit. Use the same word or phrase for "Spirit" when it refers to the Holy Spirit as you used in previous passages. For more information on Holy Spirit, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **fellowship**. For more information on fellowship, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

God also has compassion on the Philippian Christians. That means God has a deep affection and love for the Philippian Christians.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **compassion**. For more information on compassion, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

God also has sympathy for the Philippian Christians. That means God is sad when the Philippian Christians are sad.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sympathy**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that if those things are true, then Paul wants the Philippian Christians to make Paul's **joy** complete. Use the same word for joy as you used in previous passages.

Paul tells the Philippians to make Paul's joy complete by having the same mind. That means Paul wants the Philippians to think in the same way and agree with each other about the important things about following Christ.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **mind** in this context. For more information on mind, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Paul wants the Philippians to love each other. Paul also wants the Philippians to have the same **spirit** and same **mind**, meaning that they help each other and grow into better people in a way that affects their attitudes and emotions, too. The Philippians work together gladly and well, with the same purpose to follow Christ. You may or may not use your words for spirit and mind here. However, for more information on spirit and mind, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss again together the best way to translate that Paul wants the Philippians to have the same spirit and mind. Pause this audio here.

Paul does not want selfish ambition to motivate the Philippians Christians. People have selfish ambition when they try to get as much wealth and honor as they can because they only care about themselves. Paul also does not want pride to motivate the Philippian Christians. The word Paul uses for "pride" comes from two different words: empty and glory. When Paul says pride here, Paul is talking about being proud of something without having a good reason to be proud.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for this kind of **pride**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul instead wants the Philippians to have humility. This is a special word for humility that means humble thinking. This means Paul wants the Philippians to be less concerned with themselves and to work less hard to make other people think they are more important.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **humility**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul wants the Philippian Christians to consider each other as more important than themselves. Paul also wants the Philippians not to just look to their own interests or needs, or just take care of themselves, but also to take care of each other or look to each other's interests.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 2:1–4

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (924 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Philippians 2:5–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 2:5—11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:5—11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:5—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Paul has been telling the Philippian Christians to live as good citizens of God's kingdom and to make Paul's joy complete by being humble, by loving each other, and by being brave.

In this passage, Paul tells the Philippian Christians to think the same things among themselves that Christ Jesus also thought. Paul is probably telling the Philippian Christians to have the same attitude towards each other as Jesus had towards the Philippians. Paul describes Jesus' attitude in this passage.

Paul explains how Jesus humbled himself. Paul explains what Jesus did when Jesus came to earth, and then explains what God did after Jesus came to earth. Paul seems to explain this with a poem, or beautiful language. This might be because this was already a poem that the Philippian Christians knew, or Paul might have composed it as a poem so that the Philippian Christians could remember and understand these ideas better. People in Paul's culture often gave information in poems because people paid more attention to poems, or beautiful language.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of a poem that everyone knows and that is very important in your culture. Recite that poem and talk about why people like it. How do people pass the poem down to the younger generation? Why do people want everyone to know this poem? Pause this audio here.

This poem is about who Jesus is and what Jesus did. The first thing Paul says in the poem is that Jesus had God's form. That means Jesus had God's characteristics and was like God in every way—Jesus had God's power and honor. Jesus was, in fact, God.

Then Paul says that Jesus did not even try to be equal with God. Some translations say that Jesus did not consider being equal with God to be something that Jesus would try to "grasp," or hold on to, by force. This means that Jesus was completely willing to not have the same characteristics that God has.

In the next part of the poem, Paul talks about how, instead of trying to be equal with God, Jesus emptied himself and took on the form of a servant. In other words, Jesus had a human's characteristics and was like a human in every way. Jesus was, in fact, both a human being and God. Paul also says Jesus became shaped like a human and that people saw that Jesus looked like a human.

Then Paul talks about how Jesus humbled himself and how Jesus obeyed God. God asked Jesus to die, and Jesus allowed people to kill Jesus on the cross. The cross was a structure that Romans would use to kill people when they wanted those people to suffer a lot. People felt a lot of shame when the Roman government crucified them, so many people considered it to be the worst way to die.

Stop here and, together as a group, look at a photo of a cross. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people consider the worst ways to die? Why do people consider those ways so bad? Pause this audio here.

In the next part, Paul says that because Jesus was willing to die, God lifted Jesus up. In other words, God honored Jesus.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: Tell a story about someone that everyone honored. Pause this audio here.

Paul also says that God gave Jesus a name that was above all other names. Because names were so important in the culture of that time, this means that God gave Jesus more honor than God gave any other person.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: [Talk about a time when someone's name showed something important about that person.]{.mark} Pause this audio here.

Paul says that God did give Jesus this name that is above every other name, so that at the name of Jesus every knee will bow. Paul probably means that because God honored Jesus, every person will bow on their knees to Jesus to show Jesus honor and respect. Paul might also mean that when God announces Jesus' name, everyone will bow on their knees to Jesus.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of someone bowing on their knees. Pause this audio here.

People bowed in Paul's culture when they wanted to honor someone or show that person respect. People would bow in different ways, and if people wanted to honor someone as much as they could, people would bow by getting on their knees and bending until their face touched the ground. Paul is describing this method of bowing when Paul says that every knee will bow.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what kinds of things do people do to show respect to someone in an important position? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that God gave Jesus this honor so that every knee will bow in heaven and on earth and under the earth. Paul means that everyone God created, whether they are a spirit or a person, will honor Jesus. Paul wants to show that everyone who has ever lived, and even both good and evil spirits, will give Jesus a lot of honor!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, where do people think spirits live? Where do people think other beings besides people live? Where do people think dead people exist? Pause this audio here.

Next, Paul says that God gave Jesus this honor so that every tongue would confess that Jesus is lord. In other words, Paul says every person will speak out, or confess, that Jesus is lord, or master. When someone is lord, that person is in control and has power and authority over what they are lord of. Since everyone is confessing that Jesus is lord, that means that Jesus has control and power and authority over everyone.

Paul ends the poem by saying that when people honor Jesus by bowing to Jesus and admitting that Jesus is lord, people will actually also give God glory or praise, since it is God who gave Jesus that honor and authority.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone in your culture that everyone respects and praises. If that person gives honor and authority to someone else also, what happens? Do people also honor and respect the other person? Who gets the glory? Pause this audio here.

Paul calls God the Father because God was Jesus' father.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:5—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians to think in the same way as Christ Jesus thinks. Even though Jesus had all the characteristics of God, Jesus did not try to keep the same status as God.

In the second part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians that Jesus became a person with human characteristics, and Jesus obeyed God so much that Jesus died on a cross.

In the third part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians that God honored Jesus so that everyone will honor Jesus and admit that Jesus is lord.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Philippian Christians
- Christ Jesus
- God
- And every living being in heaven and on earth, both dead and alive

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that Paul was just telling the Philippian Christians that they would make Paul completely happy if they were humble and if they took care of each other.

In the first part of this passage, Paul tells the Philippian Christians to have the same mindset, or the same way of thinking, among themselves that Christ Jesus had. Paul is connecting what he just said to what Paul is about to say. In the previous part of Paul's letter, Paul said that the believers should love each other and be united in the way they act and think. Now Paul tells believers that loving each other and being united leads to them having the same way of thinking as Jesus had. Paul will continue to explain how Jesus thought and acted.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: In your culture, when people describe a person, how do they talk about the way that person thinks and then acts? Pause this audio here.

Paul then says a poem to explain Christ's way of thinking.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Paul uses poetry, or beautiful language, to talk about Jesus. How can you use beautiful language here to help people understand what Paul says about Jesus? Pause this audio here.

Paul uses contrasting phrases throughout this poem to explain how Jesus thought. Jesus had the form, or nature, of God. Jesus could have had all the privileges and rights that God has. In contrast, Jesus did not try to keep, or hold onto, those rights and privileges in order to be equal to God.

[Instead, Jesus gave up his privileges and Jesus emptied himself.]{.mark} Jesus emptied himself in the way that someone pours out water from a container. Jesus took away from himself all of his privileges as God. Jesus took the form, or the nature, of a servant. In those days, servants did not have the right to stop working for their master. Servants had low status, and the master owned the servants. In the same way, Jesus allowed God, his Father, to own Jesus completely.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you translate that Jesus emptied himself, or made himself nothing, and took the form of a servant? Pause this audio here.

Jesus put on the form of a human being. Paul repeats this idea when Paul says that Jesus looked like a man. Paul considers this to be a really important part of what Jesus did.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Paul repeats in two ways that Jesus became a human being, because Paul considers it very important. How do you emphasize something you consider really important when you are speaking? Pause this audio here.

Jesus humbled himself, or made himself low status like a servant, by becoming so obedient that Jesus was willing to die. Jesus was even willing to die by letting people hang Jesus on a cross. The most important part of this piece of the poem is that Jesus humbled himself. Paul talks about Jesus' death to explain how much Jesus humbled himself.

Because Jesus let himself die, God lifted Jesus up. Paul is using special language by using the idea of lifting something up to talk about the honor and glory that God gave Jesus. In that culture, if someone said that a person was "high," it meant that people honored that person. If people said that someone was "low," it meant that people shamed that person. The most important part of this section is that God lifted Jesus up and that God gave Jesus a name, and the rest of this part of the poem explains the result of God lifting Jesus up. God gave Jesus a name that was above every other name. When Paul talks about Jesus' name, Paul is using special language. Sometimes people talked about a person's name to talk about that person's reputation and how much other people respected and honored that person. In other words, God honors Jesus.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a person whom people really respected and honored. Pay attention to the way you talk about that person's reputation and the honor they receive. Pause this audio here.

Because of how God honors Jesus, when God announces Jesus' name, every knee will bow, whether they are in heaven, on earth, or under the earth. Angels, and perhaps people who have died and gone to heaven, are the beings in heaven. People who are alive are on earth. Some people think Paul is also talking about animals

on earth worshipping Jesus! Most likely, “under the earth” is where the spirits of dead people, and possibly evil spirits, live. In this culture, people bowed to something that they worshiped and respected. Paul compares the idea of people bowing to worship and respect someone with the way that every part of God’s creation will worship and respect Jesus.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about people showing respect to a person. What did people do to show respect? What words or phrases would be good to use here for this special language Paul is using? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Paul talks about every knee in heaven, on earth, and under the earth to show how every being, both people and spirits, both dead and alive, will honor Jesus. How will you translate “in heaven, on earth, and under the earth”? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that every tongue would confess that Jesus is lord, which will cause God the Father to receive glory. In Paul’s culture, sometimes people used the word for their tongue to talk about how people talked. Paul is saying that every person and every part of God’s creation will “confess,” or declare out loud, that Jesus is lord, or master. When people do this, people give God glory. In other words, people will understand how wonderful and majestic God is.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this poem, Paul explains that Jesus did the important task of becoming human so that people will give God glory. Think about a time you had an important task to do for an important reason. Imagine that you are explaining to your family why you need to do that task. Pay attention to the way you talk about your purposes for doing that thing. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:5—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Philippian Christians
- Christ Jesus
- God
- And every living being in heaven and on earth, both dead and alive

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians to think the same things among themselves that Christ Jesus thought. Paul explains that when Jesus had God’s form and characteristics, Jesus did not think that being equal with God was something that Jesus needed to keep.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jesus, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I do not need to keep having all the authority and power that God has; or
- I really want to help humans, so I need to be a human and be a servant.

Continue the drama.

Paul explains that instead, Jesus emptied himself, which means that Jesus took on a servant’s form and became shaped like a human. While Jesus had human characteristics, Jesus was so obedient that he died, and Jesus even let humans kill Jesus using a cross.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jesus, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am not concerned about myself. I just want to obey God and help humans; or
- This hurts so much. Being crucified is so painful and humiliating; or
- I am no longer like God. Now I have to eat and breathe, and I can die.

Continue the drama.

Paul says that because of that, God lifted Jesus up and gave Jesus a name that was above every other name.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so proud of Jesus for doing all this; or
- Because Jesus did not think about himself, I am going to honor Jesus; or
- I am so happy to give Jesus so much honor.

Continue the drama.

Paul says that God did that so that at Jesus’ name, everyone would bow on their knees, whether they are in heaven or on earth or under the earth, and everyone would admit that Jesus is lord.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing every living being, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I have to honor Jesus now because God is telling me to; or
- I love Jesus so much, and I am so excited to tell people that Jesus is lord; or
- I did not respect Jesus earlier, but now I have to admit that Jesus does have power and authority over me.

Continue the drama.

When people do this, people will glorify God.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:5–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul says that the Philippian Christians need to have the same **mind** as Christ, or think the same things among themselves that **Christ** Jesus also thought. Use the same word or phrase for mind and Christ that you used in previous passages. For more information on mind and Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul says that Jesus did not think that he needed to keep his equality with God. Instead, Jesus took a **servant’s** form. Use the same word or phrase for servant that you used in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul says Jesus became shaped like a human and that when Jesus had a human's form, Jesus **humbled** himself. Use the same word or phrase for humble that you used in previous passages.

Jesus humbled himself by being so obedient that Jesus was willing to die, and Jesus was even willing to die on a cross. A cross was a tool that Romans used to kill people. Romans would hang someone on two large beams of wood so that the person suffocated because they could not get breath easily.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **cross**. Look up cross in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Because of Jesus' name, every knee will bow, whether they are in heaven, on earth, or under the earth. When people bow, they lower their head towards someone, and sometimes people will even lower their knees to the ground as well, as Paul describes here. Heaven is where God lives with his angels. People who are "under the earth" are probably people who have died.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bow**. Look up bow in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **heaven** and for those people who have died, or are "**under the earth**." Look up heaven in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul says the tongues will confess that Jesus is **lord**. That means that everyone in heaven and on earth will admit that Jesus is lord. Use the same word or phrase for lord that you used in previous passages. For more information on lord, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul says they will do this for God the Father's **glory**. Use the same word or phrase for glory that you used in previous passages. For more information on glory, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 2:5–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (914 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Philippians 2:12–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 2:12—18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:12—18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:12—18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Paul has been telling the Philippian Christians how Paul wants them to act, and Paul just described in a poem how Jesus humbled himself and how God exalted Jesus.Now, Paul addresses the Philippian Christians as Paul's dear friends. Some translations say "beloved people," or people whom Paul loves.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call people you love when you are talking to those people? Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippians that because of everything Paul has said to them in this letter, Paul wants the Philippians to continue obeying God. Paul says that the Philippian Christians have always obeyed God. The Philippian Christians obeyed God when Paul was working with them in Philippi. But Paul has also heard that the Philippians have continued to obey God even after Paul left Philippi. Paul might also mean that the Philippians obey Paul, since Paul probably taught the Philippians most of what they knew about how to obey God. Paul says that the Philippian Christians need to work out, or complete, the work that they have to do as people whom God has saved. That means the Philippians live in the community of Christians, follow what God has asked them to do, and grow spiritually. The Christians need to remember that God is a majestic God, so they need to respect, or "fear," God. The Christians need to understand that they are weak human beings who need God's help.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that they can do the things that people God has saved should do, because God is working in them. When God works in a Christian, God is helping that Christian to follow God. God is helping each Christian to act in such a way that God fulfills God's purposes in the world. God helps the Christians want to follow God's will more and more.

Then Paul tells the Philippian Christians to do everything without grumbling or arguing. We do not know why Paul tells the Philippian Christians this. Perhaps Paul just said this because it is important for Christians to avoid

Philippians 2:12–18

complaining or grumbling. Paul might have also said this because the Philippian Christians were complaining or grumbling, but Paul does not talk about this problem anywhere else in Philippians. Paul tells the Philippian Christians that if they do everything without grumbling or complaining, then the Christians will become blameless and pure. In the religious system of the Jews, the Jews could only sacrifice an animal that was blameless, or that had no physical problems. Paul is comparing Christians who do not argue or complain with the perfect animals that the Israelites gave to sacrifice. Christians who do not argue or complain are not guilty of any wrongdoing and have no evil in them. Paul also says that these Christians will be God's children in a warped and crooked generation. That means that even though everyone else around the Philippian Christians will be evil, the Christians will be good because they will obey God in the same way a child is supposed to obey that child's parents.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: [Think about someone you know who you would consider blameless and pure. In other words, this person is innocent of wrongdoing and has no evil in this person. What kinds of things does that person do or not do?]{.mark} Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that they will shine like stars in the sky among the evil generation. Paul uses special language to say that the Philippian Christians will help people know who God is. People in Paul's culture used light to represent knowledge because light helped people see things and understand what was going on around those people. Paul might have instead meant that God will honor the Philippian Christians more than everyone else. People in Paul's culture also talked about honor and glory as if those things were light, so people would say that someone with a lot of honor was "bright." Either way, Paul wants the Philippians to think of themselves as many points of light all together.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a starry night sky. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone who knows about a lot of things. Tell a story about someone who other people honor. Pause this audio here.

Paul says the Philippian Christians will shine while they hold onto the word of life. The word of life is the message that people bring about the good news of Jesus. So when Paul says the Philippian Christians are holding on to the word of life, Paul means that the Christians are trusting Jesus and doing what Jesus told them to do, even when it is hard. When the Christians trust and obey Jesus, the Christians are like a light that shows the truth in the midst of darkness! The Christians show people who Jesus is, and that Jesus brings people true life with God! Paul might mean that the Philippian Christians will shine and show truth because the Christians do what Jesus told them to do, even when it is hard.

If the Philippian Christians really do shine like stars, Paul can boast that Paul did a good job teaching the Christians! Paul was not wasting his time! Paul is probably saying that Paul will boast "on the day of Christ," or when Christ comes back. Paul will boast that Paul did not run or work in vain. During Paul's time, people watched races in which men ran as fast as they could to see who would win the race. Paul likes to compare the Christian life to running races, so Paul is saying that Paul will be able to say that Paul lived his life well and for a good purpose.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some activities where people in your culture compete to see who can do the best? What do people think of these competitions? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and talk about a time when you taught someone something, and that person did that thing well. How did you feel? Pause this audio here.

Paul says he rejoices in all these things, even though someone pours Paul out like someone pours out a drink offering on top of a sacrifice. When Jews offered a sacrifice at the temple, people would put part or all of the animal on an altar that was always burning, and then sometimes people would also pour some wine on the altar as another part of the sacrifice. Paul says that Paul's work and Paul's suffering are like the drink offering that people offer with a sacrifice. The Philippian Christians are giving the sacrifice; the Christians are trusting Jesus and sacrificing themselves as they follow and serve Jesus. Paul is like the drink offering in that Paul is also suffering and sacrificing his own life as Paul serves Jesus. In fact, Paul's life is in danger even now!

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of someone offering a drink offering on an altar. Pause this audio here.

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Paul says that even if Paul is sacrificing himself along with the Philippian Christians, Paul is glad and rejoices. You will notice that Paul sees himself and the Philippian Christians as working together for the sake of God's kingdom. Paul and the Philippians together make the full sacrifice and drink offering that goes with it. Paul loves and deeply respects the Philippian Christians. Paul knows that he may soon die, but Paul is happy about the same things that the Philippian Christians are happy about. Then Paul says that the Philippian Christians should also be happy and that they should rejoice because of the same things that Paul is rejoicing about.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:12—18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians to keep obeying God to show that God has saved the Christians.

In the second part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians to do everything without grumbling or complaining so that the Christians will be pure people who shine like stars! Then Paul will be proud of the Philippian Christians!

In the third part: Paul tells the Philippians that Paul is sacrificing his own life for Jesus, just like the Philippian Christians are sacrificing their own lives through their service to God. Paul is happy to sacrifice himself, and the Philippians should also be happy.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Philippian Christians
- God
- Christ
- And the evil generation

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part, Paul connects this part of his letter to what Paul has just said to the Philippians. Paul probably wants the Philippian Christians to continue to obey God because of what Jesus did and what God did for Jesus, as Paul explained in the last passage.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you connect parts of a message together? How do you show that what you are about to say is the result of what you have just explained? Pause this audio here.

Paul also calls the Philippians "people I love." Paul probably says this because Paul wants to remind the Philippian Christians that Paul has a good relationship with them, so the Philippian Christians should listen to Paul!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases do you use to address people you love when you are trying to get those people to behave differently? Give an example of a time when you tried to persuade someone you love to do something different. Pause this audio here.

The main idea of the first part of this passage is that Paul tells the Philippian Christians to work out their salvation with fear and trembling. When God saves someone, God gives that person life with God forever, but God also starts to give that person good life even now with God and with each other. Paul wants the Philippian Christians to continue obeying God so that people can see that God has saved them and so that people can live in unity with one another and with God. The Philippians should "fear" God, or deeply respect God. "Fear and trembling" is a way to say that the Christians should care very much about what God thinks about them, and the Christians should work hard to obey God.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians to obey God just like they obeyed Paul when Paul was with them. And now Paul has heard that the Philippians still obey God, even though Paul is not with them!

Philippians 2:12–18

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about the Philippians working out their salvation with fear and trembling. Pause this audio here.

It is God himself who is making the Philippian Christians want to do and then do what God wants the Christians to do.

In the second part, Paul tells the Philippian Christians to do everything without complaining or arguing. This is the main idea of this part, and everything else explains why the Christians should do everything without complaining or arguing. Paul says the Christians should do everything without complaining so that they become blameless and pure. When someone is blameless and pure, that person is innocent and has done nothing wrong. Then the Christians will also be God's children among a warped and crooked generation. Paul is using special language to compare something that is crooked to people who are evil. In Paul's culture, people talked about how "straight" someone was to talk about how morally good they were. Someone who was "warped" or "crooked" was a person who was morally bad.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you describe people who do wrong things? How do you talk about the difference between people who do good and people who do evil? How will you talk about a warped and crooked generation? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that the Philippian Christians shine like stars in the sky among the evil generation, and that the Christians shine like that because they hold fast to the word of life. When the Christians "hold fast," the Christians continue to follow Christ even when it is difficult. Paul is using special language to show the difference between the Christians and the evil generation. Just like everyone can see the stars in the sky, everyone can see the Philippian Christians' actions.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you describe things that everyone can see in your culture? How will you talk about the Philippian Christians shining like stars as they continue to trust Christ? Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians to do this so that when Christ comes back, Paul can be proud that Paul did not run or work in vain. You will remember that when Paul talks about running, Paul is talking about living his life and working hard.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you worked hard for something, and that thing did not seem worth it, or it did not have a good purpose. How do you talk about working hard when it is not worth it? How will you talk about Paul being proud that Paul did not work hard for no purpose? You may have to say something like, "I lived my life for a good purpose!" Pause this audio here.

In the third part, Paul's main idea is that Paul rejoices no matter what is happening. Paul explains that Paul is joyful by talking about two types of sacrifices, or offerings. First, Paul says God is pouring Paul out like a drink offering. In other words, Paul knows that Paul is suffering for the sake of Christ. Then Paul reminds the Philippians that when they serve God, the Philippians are offering themselves to God. Paul is saying that Paul's sacrifice, or offering, to God is adding to the offering the Philippians are making to God.

Paul says that even though he is suffering for Christ, Paul still rejoices. Paul rejoices specifically over the good things God is doing for the Philippian Christians. And even though the Philippians also suffer, the Philippians should rejoice over the things God is doing for Paul!

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:12—18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul

Philippians 2:12–18

- God
- Christ
- The Philippian Christians
- And the evil generation

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that Paul loves them and that they have always obeyed God. The Philippian Christians obeyed God while Paul was with them, and the Christians obeyed God while Paul was not with them. Paul tells the Philippian Christians to work out their salvation with fear and trembling. Paul tells the Philippian Christians that they should do that because God is working in the Christians both to make them want to do what God wants and to make them do what God wants them to do.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philippian Christians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really respect God, and I am afraid of disappointing God. So I am doing what God wants me to do; or
- I am so happy that God is making me want to do what God wants me to do; or
- I am going to keep obeying God to show everyone that God has saved me.

Continue the drama.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians to do everything without complaining or arguing. Paul tells the Philippian Christians to do that so that the Christians can be blameless and innocent, and so the Christians can be God's children among a generation of people who are evil and corrupt. Paul tells the Philippian Christians that they shine like stars among this generation.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people in the evil generation, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The Christians' lives are so good that it is like the Christians are shining; or
- These Christians are so blameless and innocent. The Christians never act like we do. I wonder why?

Continue the drama.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians to hold on to the word of life so that when Christ comes back, Paul will be able to be proud that Paul did not run or labor in vain. Paul says that even if God is pouring Paul out like a drink offering to go with the offering of the Philippian Christians' faith, Paul is rejoicing, and Paul is rejoicing specifically over what is good with the Philippians.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so proud of the Philippian Christians and the fact that all my work with them resulted in people who are so faithful to God; or
- I am so happy about what the Philippian Christians are doing and what God is doing for the Philippian Christians; or
- I know a lot of bad things are happening to me, but the important thing is that the Philippian Christians are following God.

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Continue the drama.

Finally, Paul tells the Philippians Christians they should rejoice for the same reasons that Paul rejoices.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:12—18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul calls the Philippian Christians "friends," or people that Paul loves. This was a common way that friends would talk to each other.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **friends**, or "people I love." Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that, just like the Christians have always obeyed, whether Paul was present or absent, the Christians need to complete, or "work out," their salvation. When someone saves someone else, it means a person rescued someone else from a spiritually or physically bad situation.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the Philippian Christians **working out** or completing their **salvation**. Use the same word or phrase for salvation as you used in previous passages. For more information on salvation, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that they need to do this with fear and trembling. When Paul says "fear," Paul means the Christians need to respect God and understand that God is powerful.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **fear**. Look up **fear of God** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians to do everything without complaining or arguing. Paul tells the Philippian Christians they will be without fault, or blameless and **pure**. Paul also tells the Christians they will be God's children. Remember that Christians believed that God adopted them and therefore the Christians are God's children. Paul tells the Christians they will not have any faults. This is a reference to how people had to offer only perfect animals, without fault, to God. Here, it means that the Philippian Christians themselves become God's perfect sacrifice. The Christians are "pure"—they obey God and have nothing bad in them. For more information about pure, refer to the word pure in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for pure as you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **blameless**. Look up blameless in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians they will be without fault in the midst of a warped and crooked generation. This generation is evil because they are not doing what God wants them to do. Paul uses the term generation to talk about all the people who were alive when Paul wrote the letter. Paul did not mean that the people who were alive when Paul wrote the letter were the only people who were warped and crooked. You may choose to use words for crooked or warped, or you may choose to use your word for evil in this passage when you describe the generation of people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **evil** and for **generation**. Look up evil and generation in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Philippians hold firmly to the word of life. The word of life is the good news about Jesus! This good news brings true life to many people!

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **word of life**. For more information, refer to **word** in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

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Paul says that he will be proud on the day of **Christ**. The "day of Christ" is how Paul talked about when Jesus will come back and decide which people Jesus will destroy for being evil and which people Jesus will save because they are God's children. Translate the "day of Christ" in the same way you have translated it in previous passages, and see Christ in the Master Glossary for more information.

Paul says that Paul's life is like someone who pours out a drink offering to God. The Israelites poured out wine on their altar beside their other offerings to God. Paul says that the Philippian Christians are like a sacrifice to God because other people are persecuting the Christians as they serve and worship God because of their faith, or trust in God. Paul is in prison—Paul is also a sacrifice to God in prison! Paul completes the Philippians' sacrifice to God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **drink offering**, **sacrifice**, and **faith**. Look up drink offering, sacrifice, and faith in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that Paul **rejoices**, and that Paul rejoices, or is happy, with the Philippian Christians. Use the same word or phrase for being joyful as you have used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (909 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

Philippians 2:19–24

Philippians 2:19–24

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 2:19—24 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:19—24 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:19—24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Remember that Paul has just been telling the Philippian Christians how they should live as God's children and show others that God has saved them. Now, Paul transitions into explaining that Paul is sending Timothy to the Philippian Christians soon. Paul says that Paul hopes in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy soon. Paul often talks about Jesus as "Lord" when Paul wants to remind people that Jesus is the master who has all authority to make decisions in every situation. Paul is confident that he can send Timothy soon, because Paul bases his hope on the Lord Jesus who is the one who decides that Timothy can go.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time you wanted to do something you had planned to do but were not sure you would be able to do it. What made you confident that you might be able to do that thing? What were you afraid would stop your plans, and who makes the final decision about your plans? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that Paul is sending Timothy because Paul also wants Timothy to make Paul happy when Timothy comes back to Paul with news about the Philippian Christians. Paul chose to send Timothy because no one has the same mind as Timothy. That means that no one has the same way of thinking, or the same attitude, that Timothy has. Paul knows that Timothy will sincerely love the Philippian Christians in the same special way that Paul sincerely loves the Philippian Christians.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you know when someone genuinely cares about you? What kinds of things does that person do or say? Pause this audio here.

Paul says the reason no one else is like Timothy is that everyone cares about their own interests, not Jesus Christ's interests. However, we know that Paul is happy to send other people to the Philippians, too, because later, Paul will talk about how he trusts Epaphroditus. Paul is probably not talking about Paul's companions and co-workers when Paul says that everyone else just cares about their own interests. Paul is saying that, in general, many other people are not completely obeying Christ and thinking about what Christ wants. Paul contrasts Timothy with those many other people. Paul tells the Christians that they know how Timothy has proven to be a faithful person who follows Jesus, because Timothy has served alongside Paul to tell the gospel, or good news about Jesus, to others. In fact, Timothy has acted like a son who works with his father in the way that Timothy worked with Paul to share the gospel. In Paul's culture, children often helped their parents do whatever work the parents did, and children often acted as their parents acted.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some of the ways people expect children to work with their parents in your culture? How do people compare children to their parents? Pause this audio here.

Paul and Timothy worked together to tell people the message about who Jesus was, what Jesus did, and how the people needed to act in response to Jesus. Paul says that because Timothy has proven that Timothy is a good

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man who follows Jesus, Paul hopes to send Timothy to the Philippian Christians as soon as Paul knows what will happen to Paul. Paul tells the Philippian Christians that Paul also still trusts in the Lord that Paul himself will come to the Philippians soon. Earlier in this letter, Paul talked about how even though Paul was in jail, Paul was confident that God would make sure that the Roman government freed Paul and that Paul could come visit the Philippian Christians.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:19—24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: Paul says that Paul hopes to send Timothy to the Philippian Christians because Timothy loves the Philippians in the same way Paul loves them, unlike many other people who only care about their own interests.

In the second part: Paul says again that Paul hopes to send Timothy to the Philippian Christians and that Paul is confident that Paul will come to the Philippians too.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Timothy
- People who only care about their own interests
- The Philippian Christians
- And Lord Jesus Christ

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that Paul has just been telling the Philippian Christians how they should live as God's children and show others that God has saved them. Now, Paul transitions into telling the Philippian Christians what Paul is planning to do for them. Normally, Paul tells a group of Christians that Paul is sending people to them at the end of a letter, but here Paul does it in the middle of the letter. This is probably because Timothy and Epaphroditus show the qualities that Paul is telling the Philippian Christians to have.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When people in your culture write a letter or give a message, how do those people show that they are changing to a new topic? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that he hopes in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy to the Philippians. When people say "in the Lord Jesus" in the Bible, those people often mean that the thing that is "in the Lord" is going to happen if Jesus allows it to happen or makes it happen. Paul wanted to remind the people that Jesus is in control, and that whatever Jesus wants to happen will happen.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that he hopes to send Timothy to them so that the Philippian Christians can also make Paul happy when Paul hears from Timothy how they are doing. Paul wants to send Timothy because there is no one with the same spirit, or "mind," as Timothy. Timothy has a similar "mind" as Paul. Like Paul, Timothy will be genuinely concerned about the welfare of the Philippian Christians. Timothy really wants to know how the Philippian Christians are doing and to help the Philippians become better Christians.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that Timothy has the same spirit, or mind, as Paul. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that the reason other people will not be genuinely concerned about the welfare of Philippian Christians is that those people are taking care of themselves rather than obeying Jesus. Timothy, however, acts differently. Paul uses the same words here as Paul used in an earlier passage when he told the Philippian Christians to each look after each other's interests rather than just their own interests.

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Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about people who care more about their own interests, or taking care of themselves, than doing what Jesus Christ wants those people to do. Pause this audio here.

The Philippian Christians know how valuable Timothy is to their church. Timothy showed, or proved, himself to be valuable. Paul says that Timothy acted as a son acts with his father when Timothy worked with Paul to tell people the good news about Jesus.

In the second part, Paul says that because of everything Paul just said about Timothy, Paul hopes to send Timothy to the Philippian Christians. Paul is also confident in the Lord Jesus that Paul himself will come to the Philippian Christians soon. When someone is confident in the Lord, that person trusts in the Lord. The more important part of this section is that even though Paul hopes to send Timothy, Paul is still confident that Paul will come to the Philippians himself. Paul trusts in the Lord Jesus that Paul will be able to go to Philippi soon. Paul knows that Jesus is Lord, and Jesus is in control of what will happen!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show with your voice or words that Paul is stating something very important when Paul says that Paul is confident in the Lord that Paul will come to the Philippians soon? Pause this audio here.

Paul will go soon. We do not know how much time Paul thinks it will be before Paul goes to Philippi, but Paul will go after Timothy goes to Philippi and comes back to Paul to tell Paul how the Philippian Christians are doing.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you say that Paul will go to Philippi soon? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:19—24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Timothy
- People who only care about their own interests
- The Philippian Christians
- And Lord Jesus Christ

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that Paul hopes to send Timothy to them so that the Philippian Christians can cheer up Paul when Paul hears how the Philippians are doing.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

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- I really want to hear about what the Philippian Christians are doing for Jesus so that I can be happier; or
- I am glad that I can trust Timothy to go talk to the Philippian Christians and see how they are doing; or
- I want to hear how the Philippian Christians are doing and also make the Philippians happy when Timothy goes to the Philippians!

Continue the drama.

Paul says that there is no one with the same spirit or mind as Timothy. Other people do not have the same spirit because only Timothy will be genuinely concerned about the welfare of the Philippian Christians. Everyone else takes care of themselves instead of focusing on the things that Jesus wants those people to do.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people who only care about their own interests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am a Christian, but I do not care too much about other Christians because I want to take care of myself; or
- It is too hard to care about other people! or
- I know that Jesus expects me to help other people, but I do not want to.

Continue the drama.

Then Paul says the Philippian Christians know that Timothy has proven to be a faithful person because Timothy acted as a son acts with his father when Timothy worked with Paul to tell people the good news about Jesus.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Timothy, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love Jesus, and I love helping Paul; or
- I respect and care about Paul as if Paul were my father; or
- I love telling people the message about Jesus.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, Paul says that because of everything Paul just said about Timothy, Paul hopes to send Timothy to the Philippian Christians. But Paul is also confident in the Lord that Paul himself will come to the Philippian Christians soon.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:19—24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul says that Paul hopes, or confidently expects, in the **Lord** Jesus to send Timothy to the Philippian Christians soon. Use the same word or phrase here for lord as you used in other passages. For more information on lord, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **hope**. Look up hope in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul says there is no one else like Timothy, with the same spirit, or "mind." Paul means that Timothy has the same attitude, or way of thinking, that both Paul and Jesus himself had. If you use the word for "mind" in your translation, remember that "mind" refers to a person's thoughts and way of thinking.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you say that Timothy has the same **mind**, or attitude, as Paul has? If needed, refer to the Master Glossary for mind. Pause this audio here.

Then Paul says that everyone else looks out for their own interests, not Jesus'. Some translations say that everyone else takes care of themselves, not Jesus Christ. You have already translated this same idea earlier in chapter 2, verse 4, so translate this in a similar way here.

Paul refers to Jesus as **Christ** when Paul wants people to think about how God sent Jesus to save us. Use the same word or phrase for Christ as you used in previous passages. For more information on Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul reminds the Philippian Christians that they know that Timothy is valuable to the church. That means the Christians know that Timothy is trustworthy and that Timothy does helpful things. Paul says that Timothy served with Paul in the work of the good news, or **gospel**. Here, the work of the gospel means telling people the gospel, which is the message about who Jesus is, what Jesus did, and what Jesus wants us to do. Use the same word or phrase for gospel as you used in previous passages. For more information on gospel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 2:19–24

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (845 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Philippians 2:25–3:1

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 2:25—30 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:25—30 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Philippians 2:25–3:1

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:25—30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Paul talked about how Paul hopes to send Timothy to visit the Philippians soon, and how Paul hopes to come to Philippi himself soon! Paul tells the Philippians that Timothy, like Paul, cares for the Philippian Christians very much.

But Paul is not sending Timothy right now. Paul is sending Epaphroditus back to Philippi at this time, probably with this letter. The Philippians had sent Epaphroditus to Paul in prison in Rome to help Paul and perhaps to bring finances from the Philippian church to Paul. As you will remember, the Roman authorities had probably put Paul in a house and chained Paul to a Roman guard. Paul relied on friends and co-workers to bring Paul food and other things Paul needed. Paul loves Epaphroditus—Paul calls Epaphroditus Paul's brother and co-worker! Paul respects the work Epaphroditus does with Paul—Paul calls Epaphroditus his fellow soldier! As soldiers work hard together to fight a battle, Paul believes Paul and Epaphroditus worked hard together to share the good news about Jesus.

But probably while Epaphroditus was on his way to Rome, Epaphroditus got so sick that he almost died. The Philippians heard that Epaphroditus was sick, and the Philippians were extremely worried about Epaphroditus, as well as being worried about Paul in prison.

Stop here to discuss this question as a group: Have you ever been so sick that someone who loved you was worried about you? Has someone you loved ever been so sick that you were worried about them? What would you want to tell that person if you were not able to be with that person? Pause the audio here.

God had mercy on Epaphroditus, and Epaphroditus became well. Paul says that God had mercy on Paul, too, because Paul would have been very sad if Epaphroditus had died!

Paul has also been worried about Epaphroditus, probably because Epaphroditus had been so sick. And Epaphroditus is now upset because the Philippians are worried about Epaphroditus! Paul wants everyone to be happy and to not worry. So Paul decides to send Epaphroditus back to the Philippians with this letter. Paul knows the Philippian Christians will be very glad to see Epaphroditus again, and that Epaphroditus will be very glad to see the Philippian Christians again.

Stop here and talk as a group about a time when you saw someone again after a long time, and after you had been worried about that person. How did you feel when you saw that person again? Pause this audio here.

Paul wants the Philippians to welcome Epaphroditus with honor and respect. Epaphroditus' journey caused Epaphroditus to almost die, all because Epaphroditus was helping Paul share the good news about Jesus! And Epaphroditus was doing this because it was not possible for everyone in the Philippian church to come to Paul in Rome. Epaphroditus was the messenger for the Philippian church, to represent the Philippian Christians to Paul and to give Paul help on the Philippians' behalf. This is a wonderful thing for the Philippians to do, and Paul wants the Philippians to rejoice in the help they gave through Epaphroditus.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:25—30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Philippians 2:25–3:1

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: Paul tells the Philippians about how Epaphroditus got sick as Epaphroditus worked with Paul to share the good news about Jesus.

In the second part: Paul tells the Philippians to welcome Epaphroditus with joy and to honor Epaphroditus because Epaphroditus risked his life for God.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Philippians
- Epaphroditus
- God
- And Christ

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first part of this passage, Paul honors Epaphroditus as an excellent example of a good man, and someone whom Paul is proud to work with. Paul says that Epaphroditus is three things to Paul: a brother, a fellow worker, and a fellow soldier. Epaphroditus is a brother because Epaphroditus is a fellow Christian, and as God is the spiritual Father of all Christians, Christians have become like family to each other. Epaphroditus is a fellow worker helping Paul share the good news about Jesus, as Paul will explain next. Epaphroditus is a fellow soldier. Just like soldiers fight together to win a battle, the work of sharing the good news is hard, like a battle! People who work together to share the good news are like soldiers working together to do difficult things.

Paul reminds the Philippians that the Philippians sent Epaphroditus to Paul to bring Paul the Philippian's message, and to take care of Paul while Paul was in prison in Rome.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate Paul's description of Epaphroditus as a brother, fellow worker, fellow soldier, messenger, and helper to Paul. Think about times you have described a person who has helped you before. How will you describe Epaphroditus in a natural way? Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippians that what the Philippians heard about Epaphroditus is true—Epaphroditus got extremely sick and almost died. We do not know if Epaphroditus got sick on his way to Rome or after Epaphroditus arrived in Rome to help Paul. Paul tells the Philippians that God had mercy, or compassion, and healed Epaphroditus. God also had mercy on Paul because Paul is very thankful that Epaphroditus did not die. Paul says that God spared Paul "sorrow upon sorrow." In other words, if Epaphroditus had died, Paul would have been very sad. Paul had already experienced many sad things, and this would be yet another sad thing!

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about a time when someone had several sad things happen to that person, one thing after another. How do you describe extreme sadness that happens again and again? How will you say here that God spared Paul sorrow upon sorrow? Pause this audio here.

Epaphroditus really wanted to see his Philippian church brothers, and in fact, Epaphroditus was sad that the Philippians were worried about him! Epaphroditus was so sad that Epaphroditus became very upset. Because Epaphroditus was very upset, Paul was very sad for Epaphroditus! So Paul is sending Epaphroditus back to the Philippian church so that the Philippian church can be very happy and Paul can stop being worried for Epaphroditus.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Have you ever missed someone so much that you became very upset? How will you say that Epaphroditus longed to be back in Philippi and that Epaphroditus was upset because the Philippians were worried about Epaphroditus? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about a time when you were worried about someone because that person was very upset. How will you describe that Paul did not want to be worried about Epaphroditus anymore? Pause this audio here.

Philippians 2:25–3:1

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you describe the joy you feel when you see someone you love who you have not seen in a long time? What if you thought that person was going to die, but now that person has recovered? Pause this audio here.

In the second part of this passage, Paul tells the Philippians that they should welcome Epaphroditus "in the Lord" and should be glad that Epaphroditus has returned to see the Philippians. In other words, the Philippians should welcome Epaphroditus in the same way Lord Jesus would welcome Epaphroditus, and because Epaphroditus is a fellow Christian. In fact, the Philippian Christians should honor, or show great respect, for Epaphroditus because Epaphroditus almost died doing work for Christ. The Philippian Christians could not all come to Rome to help Paul. Instead, Epaphroditus was like a representative for the Philippians while Epaphroditus was with Paul, to serve Paul when the Philippians could not serve Paul themselves. Paul thinks of Epaphroditus as a symbol of the Philippians' love and friendship.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you say that the Philippians should welcome Epaphroditus "in the Lord"? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in chronological order: First, Epaphroditus is with the Philippians. Then the Philippians send Epaphroditus to Paul with an offering and to help Paul in prison. Epaphroditus works with Paul to share the good news about Jesus. Epaphroditus gets extremely sick at some point, but Epaphroditus continues to do the work of ministry with Paul. God heals Epaphroditus, but Epaphroditus is really upset that the Philippians have been worried about Epaphroditus. Paul writes this letter to the Philippians and gives it to Epaphroditus. Epaphroditus carries the letter from Rome all the way to Philippi in Macedonia. Epaphroditus reads the letter to the Philippians and gives the letter to the Philippians to continue to read.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:25—30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Philippians
- Epaphroditus
- God
- And Christ

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Set up the drama with a person to represent Paul, a person to represent Epaphroditus, and a group of people to represent the Philippians. Epaphroditus travels from Philippi to Paul and gives Paul gifts and messages from the Philippian church. Epaphroditus preaches the gospel with Paul. Paul calls Epaphroditus Paul's brother, fellow worker, and fellow soldier.

Philippians 2:25–3:1

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Philippians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- I am so glad we can send Epaphroditus to help Paul, since we cannot go ourselves; or
- We miss Epaphroditus. Epaphroditus is a good brother in Christ!

Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really like working with Epaphroditus! Epaphroditus is a hard worker and encourages me a lot! or
- I can see that the Philippians really love me, since the Philippians sent Epaphroditus to help me.

Continue the drama.

Epaphroditus gets sick and almost dies. Then God has mercy and heals Epaphroditus, and God spares Paul sorrow upon sorrow. But Epaphroditus is distressed because the Philippians are worried about Epaphroditus. So Paul sends Epaphroditus back to Philippi with this letter. In that way, both the Philippians and Paul can stop worrying about Epaphroditus.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Epaphroditus, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really miss home! Being sick has made me miss the Philippian Christians even more! or
- I love Paul, but the Philippians are really worried about me. I do not want the Philippians to be so worried. I need to see the Philippians and relieve their fears!

Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I can see that it is no longer useful to have Epaphroditus with me because Epaphroditus is really worried about the Philippians. Although Epaphroditus is a good man, Epaphroditus needs to be with his church in Philippi. That will be better for Epaphroditus and for his church; or
- I am worried about Epaphroditus. I want Epaphroditus to stay, but it is better for Epaphroditus that he leaves.

Continue the drama.

Paul tells the Philippians to greet Epaphroditus with honor because Epaphroditus risked his life to work with Paul.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Epaphroditus, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- God is so merciful to me. God healed me and allowed me to come home!

Ask the person playing Christ, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Epaphroditus has been very sick, and I am happy that Epaphroditus can come home. I want to give Epaphroditus relief and encouragement. Epaphroditus has worked hard for me!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 2:25—30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul calls Epaphroditus Paul's **brother**. In this case, Paul is using the term "brother" to mean a fellow Christian. Use the same word or phrase for "brother" when it means a fellow Christian as you have used in previous passages.

Paul also calls Epaphroditus a fellow soldier. Paul and Epaphroditus are not really soldiers who fight in a war, but men who work hard together in a difficult task. Paul often talks about Paul's work for Christ in terms of a spiritual battle against evil forces. In this way, Paul and Epaphroditus are "fighting" together to share the good news about Jesus, which means sometimes Paul and Epaphroditus are fighting against evil spiritual forces!

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that Epaphroditus is a **fellow soldier**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that the Philippians have sent Epaphroditus as their messenger to serve Paul's needs.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you say that Epaphroditus is a **messenger** from the Philippians who serves Paul's needs? Pause this audio here.

God has mercy on Epaphroditus and heals Epaphroditus, and God has mercy on Paul to save Paul from being even more sad.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that God has **mercy**, or compassion, on Epaphroditus. For more information about mercy, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Paul also tells the Philippians to welcome Epaphroditus "in the **Lord**." Paul used the title "Lord" for both Christ and God when Paul wanted to remind people that God is the master of everything. Use the same word or phrase for "Lord" as you have used in previous passages, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Lord.

Paul says that Epaphroditus almost died for the work of **Christ**. Use the same word or phrase for Christ as you have used previously, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Christ.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 2:25–3:1

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (845 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Philippians 3:2–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 3:1—11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:1—11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In previous passages, Paul told the Christians in Philippi that Paul wanted to send Epaphroditus and Timothy to the Philippians. In this passage, Paul changes the subject and begins to talk about the other things Paul wanted to say in Paul's letter. But first, Paul reminds the Philippian brothers and sisters of the most important theme of Paul's letter: the Philippians should have joy because they follow the Lord Jesus Christ!

Now Paul reminds the Christians in Philippi of things Paul probably taught them when Paul was with them. Although Paul has told the Philippians before, Paul wants the Philippians to be sure to understand where they get their righteousness from so that the Philippians do not begin to believe what false teachers might tell them.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians not to listen to people who tell them that someone needs to circumcise the Christians in Philippi. People who tell the Christians in Philippi to get circumcised want the Christians to rely on the Christians' own achievements instead of Christ.

Paul warns the believers in Philippi about a group of people that Paul describes in three different ways. First, Paul says to watch out for the dogs. In Greek and Hebrew culture, people considered dogs dirty and dangerous. So when Paul calls the people that Paul is talking about "dogs," Paul is using special language to say that those people are dangerous, and the Christians in Philippi should stay away from those people.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a dog. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do people in your culture think about dogs? What animals do people in your culture think are dirty and dangerous? Pause this audio here.

Paul also calls this group "people who do evil" and "people who mutilate themselves." Each of these three different things Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to watch out for refers to the same group of people. These are probably people who told the Christians in Philippi that someone needs to circumcise the male Christians. Paul says that the Christians are the real circumcision, or the group that is really God's people. When a person got circumcised, someone would cut the foreskin off that person's penis. God told the Israelites to circumcise their males to show that they were part of the people of Israel and one of God's people. But now God does not require people to join the nation of Israel to be part of God's people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people think about circumcision? What other ways do people cut or change their flesh? What cultural practices do people in your culture do to their bodies to show that they are part of your culture? Pause this audio here.

The Christians are the real circumcision because they are actually part of God's people. The Christians also worship with the help of God's Spirit and talk proudly about Jesus Christ. Christians do not have confidence in their own efforts or achievements, which non-believers think are important. Paul calls these things that non-

believers care about and rely on “the flesh.” Paul does not rely on these things, even though people may think that Paul has many reasons to trust in Paul’s own effort or status.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What standards for success do people in your culture have? How do those standards differ from the standards that God expects Christians to have? Pause this audio here.

In fact, Paul has more reasons to be confident that Paul has achieved many good things than anyone else. Paul’s parents had someone circumcise Paul on the eighth day after Paul was born, because all Jews were supposed to circumcise their sons on the eighth day after the son was born. Paul is a Jew, or Israelite, and Paul specifically belongs to the tribe called Benjamin. The “Jews” are the people who survived when God destroyed the nation of Israel. God divided the nation of Israel into tribes based on the 12 sons of the man whose name was Jacob, or “Israel.” Benjamin was an important tribe because Israel loved Benjamin very much, and the capital of the kingdom of Israel was in Benjamin’s territory.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people divide the people in your country into different groups? What opinions do people have about the different groups? Pause this audio here.

Paul is one of the best examples that exists of a Hebrew man. “Hebrew” is another name people used for Israelites, or Jews. Paul was also a Pharisee who obeyed the laws that God told the Israelites to obey. The Pharisees were a group of people who taught other people how to obey the law God told the Israelites to obey. A lot of people thought the Pharisees obeyed the law better than anyone else.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, who teaches people how to live the right way? What do people think about these teachers? Pause this audio here.

Paul also had so much passion for God’s law that Paul persecuted the church. Right after Jesus died and Christians started convincing people to obey Jesus, a lot of Jews wanted to persecute Christians. These Jews thought that Christians were disobeying God by worshipping Jesus. Paul had so much passion for God’s law that Paul joined these Jews when they tried to hurt and kill the Christians. Because of everything that Paul did, Paul was completely righteous, or good, according to the rules of the Jewish religious law.

But Paul considers those things that Paul used to be proud of to be a bad thing because of Christ. Paul used to rely on the things Paul did for God to save Paul, but now Paul knows that God saved Paul because of Christ. Jesus gave Paul everything Paul needed, and some of the things Paul did earlier were actually stopping Paul from worshipping Jesus. Paul considered everything to be a bad thing if it stopped Paul from knowing Christ Jesus more. Jesus is Paul’s Lord, and Paul considers knowing Jesus to be more valuable than anything else.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people think is the most valuable thing? What achievements or abilities do people consider important in your culture? What are some ways that people try to earn favor with gods or spirits? Pause this audio here.

Paul believes that now, for the sake of Jesus, or to receive Jesus and belong to Jesus, Paul has lost, or given up, everything Paul had gained before. Paul considers everything that Paul has lost to be trash. In other words, Paul has abandoned everything Paul used to do and even thinks of those things as trash. Paul most greatly values belonging to Christ and being one of Christ’s people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about your own life. What things in your life have you abandoned doing because those things are no longer important to you? What things in your life are the most valuable to you? Pause this audio here.

If Paul is one of Christ’s people, Paul will not be a good or righteous person because Paul personally obeyed the Jewish law. Instead, Paul will be a good, or righteous, person because of Jesus. Some people think that Paul says here that Paul will be righteous because Paul trusts in Jesus. Other people think that Paul means that Paul will be a righteous person because Jesus is trustworthy and Jesus promised to make Paul righteous. Both are true! We know that God makes believers have a good relationship with God, or be righteous, because Jesus makes believers righteous, and because believers trust in Jesus.

Paul wants to have a close relationship with Christ. Paul talks about two specific ways that Paul wants to have a close relationship with Christ. First, Paul wants to have a personal experience with the power that God used to bring Christ back from the dead. Some people think that Paul means that Paul wants to experience the power

of Jesus, whom God brought back from the dead. Jesus uses this power to give people who believe in Jesus a new life that helps those people not to sin. Second, Paul wants to also experience the suffering that Christ experienced by becoming like Christ in Christ's death. The Jewish and the Roman authorities killed Jesus because Jesus told those authorities what God wanted them to do, and Jesus let those authorities kill Jesus because Jesus trusted God to bring Jesus back from the dead. Paul probably means that Paul also wants to trust God enough that Paul is willing to die or do anything Christ asks Paul to do. When Paul has a close relationship with Christ, experiences Christ's suffering, and becomes like Christ in Christ's death, somehow Paul hopes that Paul will get to come back from the dead. Paul hopes that somehow, Paul's close relationship with Christ will cause Paul to come back from the dead.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to rejoice in the Lord. Then Paul tells the Christians not to listen to the people who tell the Christians to circumcise themselves.

In the second part: Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that if the things we do are important, Paul has more reasons than anyone to be confident because of the things Paul has done.

In the third part: Paul explains that the most important and valuable thing is to trust Jesus, because it is Jesus who causes people to be righteous.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Christians in Philippi
- The people who think that circumcision is still important for Christians
- The people of Israel, the Jews
- The people in the church
- Christ
- The Holy Spirit
- And God

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In previous passages, Paul told the Christians in Philippi that Paul wanted to send Epaphroditus and Timothy to the Philippians. In this passage, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi not to listen to people who tell the Christians to get circumcised.

Paul begins this section of his letter by telling the Philippian Christians that Paul has a few more things to write to the Philippians about. First, Paul says that the Philippians should always rejoice "in the Lord," or because they follow the Lord Jesus. Paul reminds Paul's brothers and sisters in Philippi that the foundation of their Christian life is the joy they have because of Jesus. Paul has already talked with the Philippians about these things, but Paul knows that if Paul repeats these things, it helps protect the Philippian Christians from false teaching.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you say that the Philippian Christians should rejoice "in the Lord"? Pause this audio here.

In the first part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to watch out for a group of people. When Paul says to "watch out," Paul is using special language. The Christians in Philippi need to be careful because these people will try to hurt the Christians in Philippi by trying to convince the Christians to believe something that is not true. When the Philippians "watch out" for these people, the Philippians actually pay attention to what these people teach and do not let these people teach something that is not what God wants people to do.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says “watch out”? Pause this audio here.

This group of people probably wanted someone to circumcise the male believers in Philippi so that they would become Jews and then become Christians. Paul calls this group of people three different names. First, Paul calls them dogs. In Greek and Hebrew culture, people considered dogs dirty and dangerous. So when Paul calls the people Paul is talking about “dogs,” Paul is using special language to say that these people are dangerous and ritually unclean, and that the Christians in Philippi should stay away from these people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to watch out for these dogs? Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul calls these people “people who do evil.” Finally, Paul calls this group of people “the mutilation.” When Paul calls them the mutilation, Paul is using special language. When people “circumcised” a person, those people cut off the foreskin of a man’s penis. Circumcision was similar to mutilation because both involved cutting or damaging someone, but people who practiced circumcision did not consider it mutilation because those people did it to honor God. So Paul calls this group “the mutilation” because Paul wants to emphasize how this practice is like mutilation, because it does not actually honor God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul calls this group “the mutilation”? Some translations call the group the “mutilators of the flesh.” Pause this audio here.

Then Paul says that the Christians are “the circumcision.” When Paul calls the Christians the circumcision, Paul is using special language again. Because Jews performed circumcision to mark that they were part of God’s people, a circumcision group came to mean a group of people who belong to God. Paul calls Christians “the circumcision” even though no one circumcises them! However, Christians are the people who now belong to God because they obey God and follow Jesus, unlike the Jews, who have chosen not to obey Jesus.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says “we are the circumcision”? Pause this audio here.

The Christians also worship with the help of God’s Spirit and boast about Jesus Christ. This is a good kind of boasting, where the believers talk proudly about what Jesus has done. Christians also do not have confidence in the flesh. When Paul talks about the flesh, Paul is using special language. Here, Paul uses “flesh” to mean the way that non-believers act and what non-believers think is important. Paul calls this the flesh because if people do not trust God, then those people only rely on the strength in their own body, or “flesh.”

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul talks about flesh? Pause this audio here.

In the second part, Paul explains that Paul does not have any confidence in the flesh, even though Paul has done many things that non-Christians think are important. In fact, Paul has more reasons to be confident in the flesh than anyone else. Then Paul lists the reasons that Paul could have confidence in the flesh. Paul’s parents had someone circumcise Paul on the eighth day after Paul was born. Paul is an Israelite and specifically belongs to the important tribe called Benjamin. Paul is a Hebrew of Hebrews. When Paul says he is “a Hebrew of Hebrews,” Paul is using special language to mean that Paul is one of the best examples that exists of a Hebrew person. A “Hebrew” is another term people used for an Israelite, or a Jew.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says Paul is “a Hebrew of Hebrews”? Pause this audio here.

Paul was also a Pharisee who obeyed the laws that God told the Israelites to obey. Paul had so much zeal, or passion, for God’s law that Paul persecuted the Christians in the church. The community of people who obeyed Jesus was called the church. Because of everything that Paul did, Paul was completely righteous, or good, according to the rules of the law that God had given the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When was a time you had to list qualifications or explain why you would be good for a certain job? How did you describe these qualifications? Then, talk about how you would translate the list of qualifications that Paul gave in a similar way. Pause this audio here.

In the third part, Paul explains that everything that Paul is and has done is not important at all compared to Christ. Because of Christ, Paul considers the benefits that Paul had because of who Paul was to be really useless. In this third part, Paul mostly refers to Jesus as just "Christ." When Paul calls Jesus "Christ," Paul wants people to think about how God had promised to send someone who would rescue the Jews from sin, and Jesus was that person. Jesus gave Paul everything Paul needed, and some of the things Paul did earlier were actually stopping Paul from worshipping Jesus. Paul considered these benefits a bad thing, or a "loss," if these things stopped Paul from knowing Christ Jesus more. Jesus is Paul's Lord, and Paul considers knowing Jesus to be more valuable than anything else. Paul emphasizes how true this is by saying it several times, with more emphasis each time.

Paul considers everything Paul had gained before a loss now for the sake of Jesus. Paul considers everything that Paul lost to be trash. When Paul says he gained Christ, Paul means that Christ is now a part of Paul's life and that Paul now belongs to Christ.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate that Paul says what Paul lost is trash and that Paul gained Christ? Pause this audio here.

Paul uses a phrase that sounds like someone finds Paul in Christ, but this phrase is special language that means that Paul wants to be completely connected to or in unity with Christ. Paul treats everything that Paul used to think had value as worthless because Paul wants to completely belong with Christ.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says that Paul wants people to find Paul in Christ? Pause this audio here.

Paul cannot become a righteous person and have a good relationship with God by obeying the law that God gave to the Israelites. In fact, no one can become righteous by obeying this law. Instead, Paul will be a righteous person because Paul trusts Jesus. Or, Paul might mean that Paul will be a good, or righteous, person because Jesus is trustworthy and Jesus promised to make Paul righteous. Since both statements are true statements, you can leave your wording vague enough that people can understand both meanings.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says Paul will be a righteous person because Paul trusts Jesus? Pause this audio here.

God is the one who gives Paul righteousness because Paul has faith, which means that Paul trusts in Christ. The righteousness that God gives is that God causes Paul to be in a right relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate that God gives righteousness because people trust in Christ? Pause this audio here.

Paul wants to know Christ. When Paul says that Paul wants to know Christ, Paul is using special language to mean that Paul wants to have a close relationship with Christ.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says Paul wants to know Christ? Pause this audio here.

Paul talks about two ways that Paul can know Christ. First, Paul can know the power of Christ's resurrection. Paul probably means that Paul can have a personal experience with the power that God used to bring Christ back from the dead. Paul might mean that Paul wants to experience the power of Jesus, whom God brought back from the dead. Jesus uses this power to give people who believe in Jesus a new life that is free from sin.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says that Paul wants to know the power of Christ's resurrection? Pause this audio here.

Second, Paul can share Christ's sufferings by becoming like Christ in Christ's death. When Paul has a close relationship with Christ, experiences the same kind of suffering Christ did, and becomes like Christ in Christ's death, somehow Paul will get to come back from the dead. Paul wants such a close relationship with Christ that Paul would be willing to do anything for Christ, no matter what suffering happens! Paul is confident that Paul will get to come back from the dead, but Paul does not seem to know exactly how Paul's close relationship with Christ will cause Paul to come back from the dead.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you translate that Paul wants to participate in Christ's suffering and become like Christ in Christ's death? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Christians in Philippi
- The people who think that circumcision is still important for Christians
- The people of Israel, the Jews
- The people in the church
- Christ
- The Holy Spirit
- And God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to rejoice! Then Paul tells the Christians that Paul has a few more things to tell them. Paul tells the Philippians to watch out for the dogs, for the people who do evil, and for the people who mutilate the flesh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people who want Christians to get circumcised, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We need the believers to circumcise the male believers and become Jews before those people can really be believers; or
- I do not like that Paul is insulting me; or
- I do not trust God to take care of me.

Continue the drama.

The believers are truly God's people, who worship God with the help of God's Spirit. The believers talk proudly about Christ and rely on Christ, not their own effort.

In the second part, Paul explains that Paul does not have any confidence in the flesh, even though Paul has many reasons to be confident. If those things were important, then Paul would have more reasons to be confident in his own status than anyone else has. Someone circumcised Paul on the eighth day after Paul was born. Paul is an Israelite, and Paul specifically belongs to the tribe called "Benjamin." Paul is a Hebrew of Hebrews. Paul was also a Pharisee who obeyed the laws that God told the Israelites to obey. Paul had so much passion for God's law

that Paul persecuted the church. Because of everything that Paul did, Paul was completely righteous, or good, according to the rules of the law.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really want the Christians in Philippi to know they do not have to trust the flesh; or
- I was very successful as a Jew; or
- I am scared the Christians in Philippi will think that the believers have to do something, like circumcise themselves, for God to save the believers.

Continue the drama.

In the third part, Paul considers the benefits that Paul had because Paul met these standards to be a bad thing because of Christ. Paul actually considered everything to be a bad thing if it stopped Paul from knowing Christ Jesus more. Jesus is Paul's Lord, and Paul considers knowing Jesus to be more valuable than anything else.

Paul considers everything a loss for Jesus's sake, and Paul considers everything that Paul lost to be trash. Paul thinks everything is trash because losing everything let Paul gain Christ. Paul also wants to be completely connected and belong to Christ. Since Paul is one of Christ's people, Paul will not be a good or righteous person because Paul personally obeyed the law that God gave to the Israelites. Instead, Paul will be a good, or righteous, person because Paul trusts in Jesus.

Paul's right relationship with God, or the fact that Paul is a righteous person, is because Paul trusts in Christ.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love Paul; or
- Since Paul trusts Jesus, I have a right relationship with Paul; or
- I do not want people to try to earn salvation.

Continue the drama.

Paul wants to know Christ even more than Paul already does. Paul also wants to have a personal experience with the kind of power that God used to bring Christ back from the dead. Paul also wants to experience the suffering that Christ experienced by becoming like Christ in Christ's death. When Paul has a close relationship with Christ and experiences Christ's suffering and becomes like Christ in Christ's death, that is how Paul will get to come back from the dead.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Christians in Philippi, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to know Christ like Paul knows Christ; or
- Paul really wants us not to accept that Christians must be circumcised; or
- I know that all I need to do is trust Christ; or
- I feel free because I am a believer, and following the Israelites' law is not what saves me!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:1—11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians to rejoice in the **Lord**. Use the same word for lord as you have used in previous passages, and refer to Lord in the Master Glossary for more information.

Philippians 3:2–11

Paul calls the people who want the believers to circumcise themselves “those who do evil.” A person who is “evil” willingly does bad things that hurt other people. When people stop obeying God, those people begin to do evil actions.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **evil**. Look up evil in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In this passage, Paul calls Christians “the circumcision.” Circumcision is the Jewish custom where people cut off the loose skin at the end of a boy’s penis. The baby’s father, or someone who was specially trained, usually did this. Circumcision happened when a baby boy was eight days old. Paul and the other apostles taught the church that God no longer required circumcision of the body in order to belong to God’s people. Instead, people need a spiritual circumcision of the heart: repentance, faith, and obedience to Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **circumcision.** Look up circumcision in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Christians worship or serve God with the help of the Spirit. When we worship God, we give honor to God. We say that God deserves all our thanks, our praises, and our respect.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **worship**. Look up worship in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Christians worship with the help of the **Spirit** of God. The Holy Spirit is the Spirit of God. Sometimes the Bible calls this the Spirit of God, the Spirit of the Lord, or sometimes just the Spirit. Use the same word or phrase for Spirit as you used in previous passages. For more information on Spirit, refer to Holy Spirit in the Master Glossary.

Christians boast in **Christ**. This is the good kind of boasting, about what Christ has done. The word “Christ” refers to the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. Use the same word or phrase for Christ as you used in previous passages. For more information on Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Christians do not have confidence in the flesh. Flesh is the soft part of a person’s body between the bones and the skin. Paul often uses the word flesh to mean the sinful way that people live without Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **flesh**. For more information on flesh, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Paul is a member of the people of Israel. Israel is the name of the territory where the Israelites lived. The name comes from Abraham’s grandson, Israel. Abraham was the first ancestor of the Israelites. Abraham’s grandson was named Jacob, but God later gave Jacob the name “Israel.” Since that time, people call Jacob’s descendants “the Israelites.”

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Israel**. Look up Israel in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul describes himself as the most Hebrew person. The word Hebrew refers to the descendants of Abraham.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Hebrew**. Look up Hebrew in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul was also a Pharisee. Pharisees were a group of religious teachers in Jesus’ time who were very concerned about obeying God’s law completely.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Pharisee**. Look up Pharisee in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Philippians 3:2–11

Paul was a Pharisee who obeyed the law. When in the Bible people talk about the law, people mean the set of instructions that God has given the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **law**. Look up law in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that Paul had a lot of zeal for the law. When someone is zealous, that person is passionately devoted to someone or something. The zealous person values that thing or person's reputation and honor.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **zeal**. Look up zeal in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul was so zealous that Paul **persecuted** the church. When people persecute you, those people are treating you cruelly and unfairly.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **persecute**. Look up persecute in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul persecuted the church. The church is a community of people who believe in Jesus. Sometimes the word church is used for a group of believers in one specific place, and sometimes the word means all the people on earth together who believe in Jesus.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **church.** Look up church in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul is a **righteous** person according to the law. Someone who is righteous is behaving in the right way and has a good relationship with God. God is righteous because everything that God does is right and good. Now, Paul says that people have this good relationship with God because they obey and follow Jesus Christ. Use the same word or phrase for righteous as you used in previous passages. For more information on righteous, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul describes himself as **blameless** under the law. When a person is blameless, that person is not guilty. Paul had never done anything against the law that would make Paul guilty. Use the same word or phrase for blameless as you used in previous passages. For more information on blameless, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul is righteous because Paul trusts, or has **faith**, in Christ. To believe and to have faith mean the same thing. If you believe in someone, you believe that what that person says about himself is true. You then trust that person and are committed to do what that person tells you to do. Use the same word or phrase for faith as you used in previous passages. For more information on faith, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul wants to know the power of Christ's resurrection. After Jesus died, Jesus became alive again after three days. We say that God resurrected Jesus. We call the event in which Jesus became alive again "the resurrection."

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **resurrection.** Look up resurrection in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Media Requests:

A picture of a feral dog that is small to mid-sized and not very hairy

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 3:2–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (836 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Philippians 3:12–16

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 3:12—16 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:12—16 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:12—16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Paul told the Christians in Philippi that Paul considers knowing Christ the most valuable thing in Paul's life. Paul hopes for the day when God causes Paul to live again after Paul dies.

Philippians 3:12–16

In this passage, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that Paul has not obtained this goal yet. What goal is Paul talking about? We are not sure. Paul might mean that Paul has not reached the goal of becoming like Christ in Christ's death. Or, Paul might mean that Paul has not reached the goal of fully knowing Christ. Paul might also mean that Paul has not yet become "perfect," or complete, as a Christian.

Paul is working hard to "take hold of," or accomplish, this goal, because Christ Jesus holds on to Paul. Christ Jesus is Paul's master, and Paul is completely devoted to Jesus, so Paul wants to obtain the goal! Paul might also mean that Christ Jesus holds onto or helps Paul so that Paul can accomplish the goal.

When Paul addresses the Christians as "brothers and sisters," Paul reminds the Christians that they are all members of God's family and that Paul loves the Christians. Paul knows that Paul is not complete as a Christian yet. But Paul loves the Philippians so much that Paul wants the Philippians to know something very important. And Paul wants the Philippians to learn this as well: Paul does not focus on what is behind him, or what has already happened, but instead Paul focuses on what is ahead of Paul. Paul talks as if Paul is running in a race. The Romans and Greeks often had competitions where people would see who could run a certain path the fastest. So in the past, Paul tried to be righteous by following the law with Paul's own strength. That is like the race that Paul has already run. That is no longer important. What is ahead of Paul is what is important: Paul still has work to do to fully know Christ and become what Christ wants Paul to be.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what competitions do people compete in? Pause this audio here.

Paul works really hard to get to the goal so that Paul can get the prize. When people ran in these races, people got a prize when they reached the end of the path they were running, which was the goal of the race. Paul calls this prize "the upward call of God in Christ Jesus." Paul might be using special language to talk as if God would call Paul up to the podium that racers would stand on when racers won a race. The racers received their prize while the racers stood on the podium. Paul also might mean that the prize is that God will call Paul to heaven, the place where God lives.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, where do people receive their prize when they win a competition? What sort of prizes do people receive for winning a competition? Pause this audio here.

When Paul says that God calls him in Christ Jesus, Paul is probably using special language to mean that the prize is Paul completely knowing Jesus Christ. Paul might also mean that God calls people because of or through what Christ has done to save us.

Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that the people who are mature, or know Jesus Christ well, have the same way of thinking that Paul has just described. If any of the Christians in Philippi thinks something different, God will reveal the truth to that person. Finally, Paul says that all the Christians, including Paul, must continue to live according to the things the Christians have already received. The things the Christians have received are the things they already know God wants the Christians to do and to be.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:12—16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that Paul is working hard to receive the prize that God is going to give Paul.

In the second part: Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to have the same way of thinking Paul has.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Christ Jesus

Philippians 3:12–16

- God
- Christians in Philippi
- And Christians who are mature

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the previous passage, Paul told the Christians in Philippi that Paul considers everything Paul has done in the past to no longer be useful, because now Paul wants to be like Christ. Paul wants to know Christ more than Paul wants anything else. To know Christ is Paul's main goal.

In the first part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi the same thing in two different ways. Paul has not become perfect yet. Paul means that Paul is not yet completely mature as a Christian. Paul has not reached the goal of becoming like Christ in Christ's death. Paul means that Paul does not yet completely do everything in the same way Christ would do it. Paul is not exactly like Christ.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a person in your culture who is very good at doing the right thing in every situation. Pay attention to what words you use to describe that person. What is the best way to translate that Paul is not yet perfect, or mature? What is the best way to translate that Paul has not yet reached Paul's goal? Pause this audio here.

Paul is working very hard to take hold of this goal, because Christ Jesus has taken hold of Paul. When Paul says that Paul will work hard to take hold of the goal, Paul means that Paul will achieve, or win, that goal like a person wins a competition. When Paul says that Christ Jesus has taken hold of Paul, Paul means that Christ is now Paul's master and that Paul is completely devoted to Christ.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about a competition or a difficult job that you really want to succeed in. How do you talk about working very hard to win or take hold of the prize, or to succeed? How will you say that Paul will work very hard to take hold of Paul's goal, because Christ Jesus is Paul's master? Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul calls the Christians in Philippi Paul's brothers. When Paul calls the Christians in Philippians his brothers, Paul is using special language to show that Paul has a close connection with the Philippian Christians. Christians believe that we are all brothers and sisters with each other because God has adopted all believers. When Paul calls the Christians in Philippi his "brothers," Paul also means that the women are like Paul's sisters.

Paul has not yet accomplished the goal of fully knowing Christ, but Paul does one very important thing: Paul forgets what is behind Paul, or what Paul has done in the past. When Paul says that Paul forgets, Paul does not literally forget what happened before. Paul means that Paul does not "focus on what is behind Paul," or think about what Paul used to do all the time. Instead, Paul "looks ahead," or works really hard to accomplish Paul's goal.

When Paul talks about what is behind Paul and ahead of Paul, Paul is using special language. Paul is talking as if Paul is running in a race. So when Paul talks about pushing forward really hard, Paul is talking about working really hard to have a close relationship with Jesus, as if Paul is running a race as hard as Paul can.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have some volunteers run a short race. Have one volunteer look forward during the race and another volunteer look backward during the race. Have each runner discuss how it felt to run the race, and discuss these questions as a group: Which way to run a race seems easiest? How is a race similar to how believers learn to obey Christ and become more like Christ? What is the best way to translate when Paul talks about Paul's life as if it were a race? What is the best way to translate when Paul says that Paul forgets what is behind him, or that Paul no longer thinks a lot about what Paul used to do? Pause this audio here.

Paul works really hard to get to the goal so that Paul can get the prize. Paul is still using special language based on races. When people ran in these races, people got a "prize," or reward, when they reached the end of the path they were running. In Paul's culture, people stood on a raised platform and everyone honored those people as they received the prize. Paul calls a Christian's prize "the upward call of God in Christ Jesus." Paul might be using special language to compare how God gives Paul a prize to how people stood on the raised platform to receive a prize. Paul also might mean that the prize is that God will call Paul to heaven. When Paul says that God calls

Philippians 3:12–16

Paul in Christ Jesus, Paul is probably using special language to mean that the prize is Paul completely knowing Jesus Christ. Paul might also mean that God calls people because of or through what Christ has done.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Paul uses the idea of a race to explain how Paul lives his life. How will you describe that Paul tries very hard to win the prize, which is really knowing Jesus Christ? How will you describe that God calls Paul upward, or to heaven, so that Paul can know Jesus? Pause this audio here.

In the second part, Paul talks about people who are mature, or perfect. People who are mature are people who have learned a lot from Jesus and are very good at understanding what God wants those people to do and doing what God wants them to do. Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that the people who are mature, or perfect, think in the same way as Paul is describing. In other words, mature Christians work really hard to have a close relationship with Christ, like a person works really hard to finish a race. If any of the Christians in Philippi think something different, God will reveal the truth to that person. Finally, Paul concludes this passage by saying that all the Christians, including Paul, must continue to live according to the things God has already taught them. God has already taught these Philippian Christians what God wants them to do and to be. Paul wants the Philippian Christians to be confident about the things they already know about God and about following God.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:12—16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Christ Jesus
- God
- Christians in Philippi
- And Christians who are mature

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that Paul has not fully come to know Christ yet. In other words, Paul has not reached Paul’s goal. Paul is working hard to accomplish the goal because Christ Jesus has taken hold of Paul.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jesus Christ, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so glad that Paul is working so hard; or
- I will always keep Paul safe and help Paul; or
- I am glad that Paul is encouraging other people with Paul’s story.

Philippians 3:12–16

Continue the drama.

Then, Paul calls the Christians in Philippi Paul's brothers. Paul has not accomplished Paul's goal of fully knowing Christ, but Paul does one thing: Paul does not focus on what has already happened, but instead, Paul focuses on what Paul needs to do. Paul works really hard to get to the goal so that Paul can get the prize. Paul calls this prize the heavenly prize God is calling people to through Christ Jesus.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy because God is taking care of me; or
- I know that God is going to help me fully know Christ; or
- I am so excited to get the prize that God is going to give me. That means I will know Christ even more!

Continue the drama.

In the second part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that the people who are mature have the same mindset, or way of thinking. If any of the Christians in Philippi thinks something different, God will reveal the truth to that person. Finally, Paul says that all the believers, including Paul, must obey what they have already learned.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Christians in Philippi, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Paul really cares about doing things God's way instead of the way Paul used to do them; or
- Paul's story is really inspiring me to also put as much work as I can into knowing Christ more; or
- I trust God to teach me what I need to know about obeying God.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:12—16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this passage, Paul calls Jesus the **Christ**. The word Christ refers to the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. Use the same word or phrase for Christ as you used in the previous passage. For more information on Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul calls the Christians in Philippi **brothers** because they are all believers in Jesus together. People often call this group of people "brothers" or "brothers and sisters" because Christians are like members of the same family with God as their father. Some Bible translations translate "brothers" as "believers." Use the same word or phrase for brothers or brothers and sisters as you used in the previous passage.

Paul works hard to win the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus. Paul may be talking about God calling Paul upward, or to **heaven**, so that Paul can know Jesus more. If you use the word for heaven in your translation, use the same word for heaven as you have used in previous passages. Refer to heaven in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate that Paul **strives**, or works hard, to **win the prize** of the **upward call** of God in Christ Jesus. Pause this audio here.

Paul says that the people who are mature, or perfect, will think the same thing Paul does. The believers are supposed to become more and more perfect, or more mature. Just like a piece of fruit is mature when it is fully developed and ready for people to use, a person is perfect or mature when they consistently act like someone who is wise and ready to act in the way God wants.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **perfect**. Look up perfect in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word
Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 3:12–16

Audio Content
- Hear and Heart (841 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Philippians 3:17–4:1

Hear and Heart
In this step, hear Philippians 3:17—4:1 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:17—4:1 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage
Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:17—4:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Philippians 3:17–4:1

Pause this audio here.

Paul has just finished explaining how hard Paul has worked to know Christ Jesus more and how much Paul values knowing Christ Jesus. Now Paul encourages the Philippians to stand firm and to follow Paul and other people's examples even when it is hard. Paul contrasts followers of Jesus with enemies of Jesus' message, and Paul encourages these followers that Jesus is coming back to transform them to be more like Jesus. Paul continues to show Paul's love for the Philippians when Paul calls them"brothers" or "brothers and sisters." [Paul encourages the Philippians to use the lives of Paul and Paul's companions as examples for how the Philippians should live. The Philippians should always be watching and following those people among them who live like Paul and Paul's companions.]{.mark}

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who are the people in your culture that people use as an example for how to live? Why are these people good examples for others? Pause this audio here.

Paul says the Philippian Christians need to follow people who live like the example Paul gave them, because many people show they are Christ's enemies by the way those people act. Paul has already told the Philippian Christians about these people, and now Paul is telling the Philippians again. Paul has tears in his eyes because of how sad Paul is about what these enemies are doing. Paul says these people are enemies of the cross of Christ. This means these people work against everything Christ accomplished when Christ sacrificed himself on the cross. These people act like they hate the message about Christ dying on the cross.

Paul says that in the end God will destroy these enemies of Christ. Paul goes on to describe the kinds of things these people do. Instead of worshipping the Creator God, these people's god is their stomach. In other words, these people worship things that bring these people pleasure. Paul also says these people's glory is their shame. Some translations say these people boast about shameful things. Paul means that these enemies are proud of the terrible things they do, when instead, these enemies should be ashamed of these things.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time someone in your culture was proud of something they did, but everyone else thought that thing was shameful. How did people in the culture react? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that these enemies have their minds set on earthly things. In other words, these people only think and care about things that have nothing to do with God. So these people probably focused on getting drunk, eating rich food, having lots of money, and wearing expensive clothes, and these people did not focus on what God wanted them to do.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are some things that people in your culture want to have so that they can have a good life? How do these things sometimes keep people from knowing God well? Pause this audio here.

Paul contrasts these enemies with Christians and reminds the Christians of something Paul has told the Christians before. Christians' citizenship is in heaven, which means Christians belong to God and do what God wants them to do in the same way a person who is a citizen of a country or kingdom does. Paul reminds the Philippian Christians that they are waiting for a Savior to come from heaven, and that the Savior the Christians are waiting for is the Lord Jesus Christ.

Jesus will transform our humble bodies. Right now, human bodies can break and die, so these bodies are not really very impressive. That is why Paul calls our bodies the bodies of our humiliation.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do people in your culture think about human bodies? Do people consider human bodies strong or weak? Do people consider human bodies tough or fragile? Pause this audio here.

Paul says that Jesus will transform our humble bodies so that they can be like the body of Jesus' glory. When Jesus went to heaven, Jesus got a new body that does not break in any way or die, and Jesus promised to give Christians new bodies like his. That is what Paul is talking about here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do people in your culture think happens when a person dies? How does that compare to what Paul is describing here? Pause this audio here.

Philippians 3:17–4:1

Jesus will transform Christians' bodies using the power that made Jesus able to make everything obey Jesus. Since God created everything, and since God is all-powerful, God can make everything obey God. Even though people and spirits rebel against God, God can end their rebellion whenever God wants to, and God has promised that God will end the rebellion one day. That is what Paul is talking about when Paul says Jesus has the power to make everything obey Jesus.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, who or what do you consider to be the most powerful being? How did that person or thing become the most powerful being? Pause this audio here.

Then Paul tells the Philippian Christians to stand firm in the Lord because of everything Paul just said about Jesus. Paul loves the Philippians, and Paul shows that again when Paul calls the Philippians brothers and sisters, the people Paul loves and wants to be with, and the people who make Paul happy. Paul also says that the Philippians make Paul proud like a winner in a race is proud of his crown of victory.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a victory crown. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: When do people in your culture give rewards? What sort of rewards do people give? Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul encourages the Philippians to stand firm, or to do the things Paul told them to do and not give up when it is difficult to do those things. As Paul begins the final parts of Paul's letter, Paul wants to remind the Philippians of how much Paul loves them and how much Paul is proud of them.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:17—4:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four parts.

In the first part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians to imitate Paul and the other Christian leaders.

In the second part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians about Jesus' enemies who God will eventually destroy.

In the third part: Paul reminds the Philippian Christians what Jesus is going to do for the Christians.

In the fourth part: Paul reminds the Philippian Christians how important they are to Paul and tells the Philippians to stand firm in the Lord.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Philippian Christians
- The enemies of Jesus Christ
- And the Lord Jesus Christ

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Paul has just finished explaining how hard Paul has worked to know Jesus more and how much Paul values knowing Jesus more than Paul values anything else. Now, in the first part, Paul calls the Philippian Christians Paul's brothers and sisters and tells the Philippian Christians to unite together by imitating what Paul has done and what Paul is doing. Paul also tells the Philippian Christians to watch the people who are already doing what Paul and Paul's companions taught them to do to follow Jesus, so they can imitate those people well.

In the next part, Paul says the Philippian Christians need to continue to follow Paul's example because many people show they are working against what Jesus did when Jesus sacrificed himself on a cross.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how would you say that someone was working against a certain situation? For example, how would you say someone was working against a marriage or a funeral? How

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will you translate that these people are enemies of, or are working against, what Jesus did on the cross? Pause this audio here.

Paul has already told the Philippian Christians about these people, and now Paul is telling them again about these enemies of Jesus Christ. Paul is telling the Philippians with tears in Paul's eyes. The tears in Paul's eyes mean that Paul is crying because Paul is sad.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people show they are sad? How will you translate this part of the letter to show that Paul is sad? Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul quickly lists four things that these enemies of Jesus do. The way Paul talks about these enemies makes the audience feel like these enemies are terrible! First, Paul says that God will destroy these people. Second, Paul says that these enemies of Jesus will do anything to satisfy whatever desires they have. These enemies' gods are their stomachs.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that these people's gods are their stomachs, or that these people will do anything to satisfy their desires. Pause this audio here.

Third, Paul says these enemies' glory is their shame. In other words, these people are proud of the terrible things that they do, but they should be ashamed of these things. Finally, Paul says that the enemies are always thinking about how they can have nice things while they are on earth, rather than listening to and following what God wants for them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If you are describing the terrible actions of someone, how will you list those actions in a story or conversation? Pause this audio here.

In the third part of this section of the letter, Paul contrasts these enemies with Christians. Paul describes that Christians belong to God and do what God wants them to do. In fact, Christians are citizens of heaven, God's territory, in the same way a person is a citizen of their country, belongs to their country, and follows the laws of their country. Paul reminds the Philippian Christians that they are waiting for a Savior to come from heaven, and that the Savior the Christians are waiting for is the Lord Jesus Christ. Paul refers to Jesus as "Lord" when Paul wants people to think about how Jesus has authority over them and over everything in the universe. Paul refers to Jesus as "Christ" when Paul wants the people to think about how God sent Jesus to earth to save people. When Paul uses all three titles to refer to Jesus, Paul is trying to get people to really think about how amazing and powerful Jesus is, and to think about everything Jesus has done and has promised to do.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about a very important and powerful person in your area. When you are talking about that person, how do you talk about him? What kinds of titles do you give to that person, and why? Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that because they are citizens of heaven, Jesus will transform their humble bodies so that they can be like Jesus' glorious body. And Jesus will do that using the power that allowed Jesus to make everyone and everything obey Jesus. When Jesus went to heaven, Jesus got a new body that does not break in any way or die, and Jesus promised to give Christians new bodies like his. That is what Paul is talking about here.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about Jesus transforming, or changing, our humble bodies to be like Jesus' glorious body. Pause this audio here.

Then, in the fourth and final part, Paul reminds the Philippian Christians how much Paul cares about them. Paul does this by calling the Philippian Christians six things. Paul calls the Philippians "brothers and sisters" because Christians believe we are all brothers and sisters, and we should love each other because we are all part of God's family. Paul calls the Philippians "his beloved and his desired," which means he loves them and wants to be with them. Paul calls them his joy and his crown. Paul calls the Philippians his joy because Paul is so happy that they are obeying God and becoming more loving and mature. Paul calls them his crown because Paul is proud of the Philippian Christians. In the Roman Empire that Paul and the Philippians lived in, people competed in races to see who could run the fastest. The people who organized the race gave the person who ran the fastest a crown to reward that person for their victory. It was also the proof that they had won the race. Paul is saying that the Philippian Christians are Paul's reward for obeying God really well, and the proof that Paul obeyed God well. Paul

Philippians 3:17–4:1

is calling the Philippian Christians all these things to remind them that they can trust Paul and to show that what Paul has said to them is very important.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are some ways people tell others that they love those people? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate that Paul calls the Philippian Christians Paul's "crown"? Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people show that certain things those people say are more important than other things they say? Pause this audio here.

After Paul shows the Philippian Christians how much he loves them, Paul tells the Christians to stand firm in the Lord by doing the things Paul has taught them to do. When Paul told them to stand firm, Paul wanted them to stay loyal to Jesus. When people do things "in the Lord," it means people do those things because Jesus wants them to do them, and those people rely on Jesus to help them do those things.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you translate that Paul told the Philippians to stand firm in the Lord in the way Paul has taught them to? Pause this audio here.

Finally, Paul again calls the Philippians the people "he loves."

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:17—4:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- The Philippian Christians
- The enemies of Jesus Christ
- And the Lord Jesus Christ

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, Paul calls the Philippian Christians Paul's brothers and sisters and tells the Philippian Christians to unite together and imitate what Paul has done and what Paul is doing. Paul also tells the Philippian Christians to watch the people who behave as Paul and the other people who taught the Philippian Christians about Jesus told them to behave, so the Philippian Christians can behave like them.

In the next part, Paul says the Philippian Christians need to do this because many people show they are working against the things Jesus did by sacrificing himself on a cross. Paul has already told the Philippian Christians

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about these people, and now Paul is telling the Philippians about these people again. Paul also says that he is telling the Philippians with tears in Paul's eyes because of how sad Paul is about what these enemies are doing.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so sad because I know that people will try to hurt the Philippian Christians; or
- I want these enemies to realize how much Jesus loves them so that these enemies stop opposing Jesus; or
- I really hope the Philippian Christians listen to me because this is important, and I am scared for the Christians.

Continue the drama.

Paul says that in the end God will destroy these people. These enemies will do anything to satisfy whatever desires they have. These enemies are proud of the terrible things that they do, when they should be ashamed of those things. Finally, Paul says that the enemies are focused on how they can have nice things while they are on earth rather than on listening to God.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the enemies, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not care about God; I just want to have good things in life; or
- I am so proud of myself for doing awful things; or
- I will do anything to make sure that I can be comfortable and satisfy my desires.

Continue the drama.

In the third part, Paul contrasts these enemies with Christians. Paul says that Christians belong to God and do what God wants Christians to do. Paul reminds the Philippian Christians that they are waiting for a Savior to come from heaven, and that the Savior the Christians are waiting for is the Lord Jesus Christ.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that Jesus will transform our humble bodies so that our bodies can be like Jesus' glorious body, and that Jesus will do that using the power that allowed Jesus to make everyone and everything obey Jesus.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Lord Jesus Christ, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so excited to change Christians' bodies so that their bodies can be like my body; or
- I have the power to do whatever I want, and I want to use that power to help the people who obey me have better bodies; or
- I am going to save the people who obey me because I love those people.

Continue the drama.

Then, in the fourth and final part, Paul reminds the Philippian Christians how much Paul cares about them. Paul calls the Philippian Christians Paul's brothers and sisters, the people Paul loves and wants to be with, the people who make Paul happy, and Paul's reward for doing a good job. Paul tells the Philippian Christians to stand firm in the Lord because of everything Paul just said about Jesus.

Finally, Paul calls the Philippian Christians his beloved again.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really want the Philippian Christians to know how much I love them; or
- The Philippian Christians need to be strong, or the enemies will beat the Christians; or
- I hope the Philippian Christians understand how important it is that they stay loyal to Jesus.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 3:17—4:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Philippians 3:17–4:1

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians to unite together by imitating what Paul has done and what Paul is doing. Paul calls the Philippian Christians here "**brothers**," or "brothers and sisters." Use the same word or phrase to translate brothers and sisters as you used in previous passages.

Paul says the Christians need to do this because many people show they are **Christ**'s enemies with their behavior. Paul refers to Jesus as "Christ" when Paul wants people to think about how God sent Jesus to save people. Use the same word or phrase to translate Christ as you used in previous passages. For more information on Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul says these people are enemies of the **cross** of Christ. This means these people work against everything Jesus accomplished when Jesus sacrificed himself on the cross. The cross was two beams of wood that crossed each other, and the Romans used a cross to kill people when the Romans wanted the person they were killing to suffer a lot. Here, Paul is using the word "cross" to refer to the fact that when Jesus died on the cross, Jesus provided a way for people to stop sinning and for them to avoid the consequences of the sin they had already done. Use the same word or phrase for cross that you used in previous passages. For more information on cross, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul says that in the end God will destroy these people. Paul also says that these people's god is their stomach. A god is something that people worship other than the one true Creator God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **god**. Look up **gods** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul also says their **glory** is their shame. Paul means these enemies are proud of the terrible things that they do, when these enemies should be ashamed of those things. Use the same word or phrase for glory as you used in previous passages. For more information on glory, refer to the master glossary.

People feel ashamed or humiliated when they realize they have done something wrong. When people shame each other, they humiliate or dishonor each other.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **shame**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul also says that these enemies think about earthly things. Paul used the phrase "earthly things" to talk about things that have nothing to do with following God. So these people probably focused on getting drunk, eating rich food, having lots of money, and wearing expensive clothes, and they did not focus on what God wanted these people to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **earthly things**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul contrasts these enemies with Christians. Paul says that Christians are citizens of **heaven**, which means Christians belong to God and do what God wants Christians to do, like a person belongs to their country and follows the laws of their country. Use the same word or phrase for heaven as you have used in previous passages, and refer to heaven in the Master Glossary for more information.

Paul reminds the Philippian Christians that they are waiting for a Savior to come from heaven. A Savior is a person who saves someone, or rescues that person from a dangerous or difficult situation.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Savior**. Look up Savior in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Savior the Christians are waiting for is the **Lord** Jesus Christ. Paul refers to Jesus as "Lord" when Paul wants people to think about how Jesus has authority over those people and over everything in the universe. Use the same word or phrase to translate Lord as you used in previous passages. For more information on Lord, refer to

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the Master Glossary. When Paul uses all three titles to refer to Jesus, Paul is trying to get people to really think about how amazing and powerful Jesus is, and to think about everything Jesus has done and has promised to do.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that Jesus will transform the "body of our humiliation," or our humble bodies, into bodies of glory like Jesus' body. Right now, human bodies can break and die, so these bodies are not impressive. That is what Paul is talking about when Paul calls these bodies "the body of our humiliation." We are humble while we use these bodies because we do not have much power.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **humiliation**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Then Paul calls the Philippian Christians Paul's crown. Paul calls the Christian's his crown because Paul is proud of the Philippian Christians. People who organized races in Paul's culture gave the winner of a race a crown to reward them for their accomplishment. The crown was also proof that the person had won the race. Paul is saying that the Philippian Christians are Paul's reward for obeying God really well, and the proof that Paul obeyed God well.

Stop here and look at the photo of a crown together as a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **crown**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Finally, Paul again calls the Philippian Christians his friends, or the people that Paul loves. Paul is using all these terms to show how much Paul cares about the Philippian Christians, and to show the Christians that what Paul is saying here is really important. Use the same word or phrase for "**people that I love**" as you used in Philippians 2:12.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 3:17–4:1

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (841 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.5 MB)

- Embodying the Text (3.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Philippians 4:2–9

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 4:2—9 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:2—9 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:2—9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In previous passages, Paul has been warning the Philippian Christians about false teachers and encouraging the Christians to remember that they are citizens of heaven—they belong to God! In this passage, Paul begins a new subject. Paul talks about two women: Euodia and Syntyche. Paul strongly urges these women to have the same mind in the Lord. Euodia and Syntyche had probably been disagreeing with each other. Paul wants Euodia and Syntyche to think in similar ways again, and Paul wants these women to agree with each other by relying on Jesus to help them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people resolve conflicts? If two people are arguing, how do people try to get those people to stop? Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul asks someone to help Euodia and Syntyche. Paul calls this person Paul's loyal companion or Paul's true partner. Paul does not say who Paul is talking to. Paul tells this partner to help Euodia and Syntyche because they did hard work with Paul to tell people the gospel, or the good news about Jesus. Paul says that Paul and Euodia and Syntyche worked with Clement and Paul's other co-workers to tell people the gospel. Paul says that all their names are in the book of life. In Paul's culture, the people in charge of a city or other area would write down the name of anyone who lived in that city or area in a book. Anyone whose name was in the book belonged to that place. Paul says that these people's names are in the book of life. This means that these women belong to, or are citizens of, God's kingdom. People who belong to God's kingdom will live forever with God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture know if someone belongs in a certain place or group? How does someone join or leave a place or a group? Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul returns to the main theme of Paul's letter. Paul says twice that the Philippian Christians should rejoice, or be happy, in the Lord. This time, Paul adds that the Christians should be happy in the Lord all the time. That means Paul wants the Philippian Christians to celebrate that they belong to Jesus. Paul tells the Philippian Christians that everyone around the Christians needs to know that they are gentle people. Gentle people do not attack people who attack them, and gentle people also respect other people and do not insist that they are always right.

Then Paul reminds the Philippian Christians that the Lord is near. Paul probably means that soon Jesus will come back to earth and Jesus will decide who Jesus rewards for obeying Jesus and who Jesus punishes for disobeying Jesus. Paul might also mean that Jesus is always close to the Philippian Christians. Paul tells the Christians that

the Lord is near so that they remember why they need to be gentle even when the Christians struggle to be gentle.

Then Paul tells the Philippian Christians not to worry about anything. Instead, whenever anything happens, the Christians need to pray and tell God that they need help. Paul also tells the Christians that when they tell God they need help, the Christians need to have an attitude of thanksgiving because they know that God has done good things for the Christians, and the Christians know that God hears them.

Paul says that when the Philippian Christians pray and ask for help, God will give peace to the Philippians' feelings and thoughts as they follow Christ Jesus. When Christians have God's peace, they have a good relationship with both God and with other people. God's peace causes us to be calm and not worry, even when the situation around us is bad.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe someone you know who has peace. In other words, that person has a good relationship with God and with others, and that person does not allow their situation to make them worried. Pause this audio here.

Paul again starts to finish his letter. Paul wants to tell the Philippian Christians some important things and behaviors that they should always be thinking about. The first thing Paul wants the Philippians to think about is things that are true. In other words, the Philippians should think about things that they can trust to be good. Paul wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that are "noble," or things that are worthy of respect. Paul wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that are "just," or ways that God treats people fairly according to his law. Paul wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that are "pure," or things that are not sinful in any way. Paul wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that are "lovely," or things that are worthy of love. Paul also wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that people can admire or respect. Paul says that when something is "excellent" or worthy of praise, the Philippian Christians should think about it. If something is excellent, then it is very good. These good things are very good in a moral sense —these are things that God admires or approves of. If something is worthy of praise, then people admire that thing or approve of it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what kinds of things does a good person do? For example, does that person need to be generous, or fair, or follow the rules well, or help others? Listen to Paul's list of good qualities again. How do these good qualities compare to the good qualities someone in your culture should have? Pause this audio here.

Paul then tells the Philippian Christians to keep doing the things that they have learned, received, heard, and seen Paul doing. Paul has probably been doing many of the things Paul has just described as things the Philippians should be always thinking about! Paul says that if the Philippian Christians do those things, then the God of peace will be with the Christians. Paul refers to God as the "God of peace" because God gives people peace. When God is with people, God protects those people and blesses them and helps them through difficult situations.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:2—9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: Paul asks Euodia and Syntyche to agree with each other.

In the second part: Paul tells the Philippian Christians to be joyful, gentle, and to pray to God instead of worry.

In the third part: Paul encourages the Philippian Christians to always be thinking about and filling their lives with good things and actions that bring an environment where God, who brings peace, can work.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul

Philippians 4:2–9

- Euodia
- Syntyche
- Paul's loyal companion
- Clement
- Paul's other co-workers
- The Philippian Christians
- Christ Jesus
- And God, the Father

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In previous passages, Paul has been warning the Philippian Christians about false teachers and encouraging the Christians to remember that they are citizens of heaven—they belong to God!

In the first part of this passage, Paul begins a new subject and talks about a very personal and specific matter. Paul gives the names of two women: Euodia and Syntyche. Paul strongly urges Euodia and Syntyche to agree with each other. Paul asks these women to "have the same mind," or to think in the same way. Paul wants these women to agree by relying on Jesus for help.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that Paul wants Euodia and Syntyche to "have the same mind," or to think in the same way together, because they are two women who follow Jesus. Paul asked the Philippians to have the same mind with Paul in Philippians 2:2. You may listen to your translation of Philippians 2:2 and translate this phrase here in the same way. Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul asks someone to help Euodia and Syntyche. Paul calls this person Paul's loyal companion or Paul's true partner. Paul tells this partner to help Euodia and Syntyche because they did hard work with Paul to tell people the gospel. Paul and Euodia and Syntyche worked with Clement and Paul's other co-workers to tell people the gospel. Paul says that all of these co-workers' names are in the "book of life." In Paul's culture, the people in charge of a city or other area would write in a book the name of anyone who lived in that city or area. Anyone whose name was in the book belonged to that place. In a similar way, anyone whose name God writes in the book of life belongs to God's kingdom. That person will have life forever with God.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do you know someone is part of a specific group? What is the best way to translate that all these names are in the book of life? Pause this audio here.

Paul does not connect the second part of this passage with the previous part. But in this part, Paul encourages the Philippian Christians to act in a certain way. First, Paul tells the Philippians to "rejoice," or always celebrate that they belong to Jesus. Then Paul repeats that the Philippians should rejoice. Paul tells the Philippians to rejoice twice because Paul thinks it is very important for the Philippian Christians to be happy about what God is doing for them. Paul also adds that the Philippian Christians should rejoice all the time!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, why would someone repeat a command and tell people to obey that command all the time? How will you say that Paul says, "Rejoice in the Lord always. Again, I say to rejoice!"? Pause this audio here.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that everyone around them needs to know that they are gentle people. When a person is gentle, that person consider others' thoughts and feelings. That person takes care of others in their community and does not fight people with their words or actions.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who is someone you know who is a gentle person? Pay attention to the words you would use to describe that person. How will you say that the Philippian Christians should show everyone that the Christians are gentle? Pause this audio here.

Then Paul reminds the Philippian Christians that the Lord is near, so that the Christians remember that it is important to be gentle even when they struggle to be gentle. When Paul says the Lord is near, Paul probably means that Jesus is coming back to earth soon. When Jesus comes, Jesus will judge everyone based on their actions. Paul may also mean that Jesus is always helping and listening to the Philippians, even now.

Then Paul tells the Philippian Christians not to worry about anything. Instead, whenever anything happens, the Christians need to pray to God and tell God they need help. Paul also tells the Christians that when they tell God

Philippians 4:2–9

they need help, the Christians need to be thankful. If the Philippian Christians ask God to help them and they are thankful when they ask God, then God's peace will guard the Philippian Christians' hearts and minds in Christ Jesus. In Paul's culture, people thought that the heart was where people feel emotions and make decisions, and that the mind was where people think. When God's peace guards the Philippian Christians' hearts and minds, God stops bad thoughts and bad situations from negatively affecting the emotions and thoughts of the Philippian Christians. God's peace will guard the Philippians as they follow and obey Christ Jesus. God's peace is more powerful than people can understand.

Stop this audio here and discuss this question as a group: In step two, how did you describe a person who lived in peace? How will you say that God's peace will guard the Philippian Christians' hearts and minds in Christ Jesus? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about having so much peace that it affects everything you do, and you cannot even understand how you have so much? Pause this audio here.

In the final part, Paul addresses the Philippian Christians as brothers and sisters again and tells them the kinds of things they need to be thinking about and doing. Paul lists many good qualities. The list consists of things that are true, things that are noble, things that are just, things that are pure, things that are lovely, and things that people should admire. Paul also adds anything that is excellent or worthy of praise. Then, Paul tells the Philippian Christians to fill their minds with thoughts about these good things.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people list things they think are important? If a wise person is giving advice to someone else, and the wise person wants to tell that other person what kinds of good things to think about, how would they do that? Try doing that with each other now and pay attention to how you list these good things. Pause this audio here.

Paul then tells the Philippian Christians that Paul wants the Christians to keep doing the things they learned from Paul, and the things Paul gave them, the things they heard about Paul doing, and the things they saw Paul do. Paul does not think that the Philippian Christians have not already been doing the things Paul did, but Paul is encouraging the Christians to continue doing those things. Paul says that if the Philippian Christians do those things, then God himself, who gives peace, will be with them.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:2—9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- Euodia
- Syntyche
- Paul's loyal companion
- Clement
- Paul's other co-workers
- The Philippian Christians
- Christ Jesus
- And God, the Father

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part of this passage, Paul strongly urges Euodia and Syntyche to agree with each other, and Paul wants these women to agree by relying on Jesus to help them.

Then, Paul asks his loyal companion to help Euodia and Syntyche. Paul tells this partner to help Euodia and Syntyche because they did hard work with Paul to tell people the gospel. Paul and Euodia and Syntyche worked with Clement and Paul's other co-workers to tell people the gospel. Paul says that all their names are in the book of life.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Euodia, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am mad at Syntyche, even though we are both Christians; or
- I have done so many good things for Jesus with Paul. I feel embarrassed that Paul had to tell me to agree with Syntyche in front of the whole Philippian church; or
- I am so grateful that Paul and other people are helping me work through this disagreement with Syntyche.

Continue the drama.

In the next part, Paul tells the Philippian Christians to always celebrate that they belong to Jesus. Then Paul repeats that Paul wants the Christians to rejoice.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really think it is important for the Philippian Christians to celebrate all the amazing things God has done for them; or
- I am so happy about all the great things God has done for me. I hope the Philippian Christians are also happy.

Continue the drama.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that everyone around them needs to know that they are gentle people. Then Paul reminds the Philippian Christians that the Lord is near. Paul tells the Philippian Christians not to worry about anything. Instead, whenever anything happens, the Christians need to pray to God and let God know they need help. Paul also tells the Christians that when they tell God they need help, the Christians need to be thankful because God hears them. If the Philippian Christians ask God to help them and they are thankful when they ask God, then God's peace will guard the Philippian Christians' hearts and minds in Christ Jesus.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philippian Christians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- There are a lot of things that God expects me to do; or
- I am so glad that God is close to me and that God helps me be a better person; or
- I am so calm because God is helping me deal with the problems in my life.

Continue the drama.

In the final part, Paul addresses the Philippian Christians as brothers and sisters again and gives them a list of the kinds of things that the Christians should think about. Paul tells the Christians to think about things that are true, things that are noble, things that are just, things that are pure, things that are lovely, and things that

Philippians 4:2–9

are admirable. Paul also wants the Christians to think about anything that is excellent or worthy of praise. Paul tells the Philippian Christians to think about the things in this list.

Paul then tells the Philippian Christians that Paul wants the Christians to keep doing the things they learned from Paul, and the things Paul gave the Christians, the things they heard about Paul doing, and the things they saw Paul do. Paul says that if the Philippian Christians do those things, then the God of peace will be with the Christians.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The Philippian Christians are doing so many good things. I am so proud of the Philippian Christians; or
- I have such a good relationship with the Philippian Christians because they are doing what Paul told them to do; or
- I love the Philippians so much, and I am giving them peace so they can continue to follow me.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:2—9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Paul strongly urges Euodia and Syntyche to have the same mind, or agree together, in the **Lord**. Paul refers to Jesus as Lord when Paul wants people to think about the power and authority Jesus has. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you used in previous passages. For more information on Lord, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then Paul asks his loyal companion to help Euodia and Syntyche because these women did hard work with Paul to tell people the **gospel**. Paul uses the word gospel to refer to the message about what Jesus did to save people. Use the same word or phrase for gospel as you used in previous passages. For more information on gospel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul says that the names of Euodia and Syntyche, along with Clement and other coworkers, are in the book of life. In Paul's culture, the people in charge of a city or other area would write down the name of anyone who lived in that city or area in a book, to show that those people belonged to that place. People who belong to God's kingdom would live forever, so if your name is in the book that records people who belong to God's kingdom, you will have life forever.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **book of life**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Then, Paul tells the Philippian Christians to **rejoice** in the Lord always. That means Paul wants the Philippian Christians to celebrate that they belong to Jesus, and Paul does not want the Christians to ever get less happy that they belong to Jesus. Use the same word or phrase for rejoice that you used in previous passages.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that everyone around them needs to know that the Christians are gentle people. Gentle people do not attack people who attack them, and gentle people also respect other people and do not insist that they are always right.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **gentle**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Then Paul tells the Philippian Christians not to worry about anything. Instead, whenever anything happens, the Christians need to pray, or talk to God, and they need to tell God that they need help. Paul uses two different words for "pray" in this passage. First, Paul uses the general word for prayer which means to talk to God. Then Paul uses a special word for prayer that means to tell God the things that you need.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the kind of praying where someone is asking for help. This is the same word you used in Philippians 1:4 and Philippians 1:19. For more information on the general word for **prayer**, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Philippians 4:2–9

Paul also tells the Philippian Christians that when they tell God they need help, the Christians need to thank God for what God has done.

Then, God's **peace**, which is greater than anyone could understand, will guard the Philippian Christians' hearts and minds in Christ Jesus. God's peace refers to the way God brings good relationships to all parts of Christians' lives. This peace includes the way God restores God's relationships with Christians, and also how God helps Christians be calm and not worry even when the situation around them is bad. Use the same word or phrase for peace as you used in previous passages. For more information on peace, refer to the Master glossary.

When Paul says that peace will guard the Philippian Christians' **heart** and **mind**, Paul is using special language. In Paul's culture, people thought that the heart was where people feel their emotions and make decisions, and that the mind was where people have thoughts. When God's peace guards the Philippian Christians' hearts and minds, God stops bad thoughts and bad situations from negatively affecting the emotions and thoughts of the Philippian Christians. Use the same words or phrases for heart and mind as you used in previous passages. For more information on heart and mind, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then Paul addresses the Philippian Christians as **brothers and sisters** again. Use the same word or phrase for brothers and sisters as you used in previous passages.

Paul tells the Philippian Christians that the final thing Paul wants to tell the Christians is to think on certain things. The first thing Paul wants the Philippians to think on is whatever is true. That means something that people can trust because it does not confuse or deceive people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **true**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul also wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that are "noble," or things that are worthy of respect.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **noble**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul also wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that are "just." That means whatever God or people do that treats people fairly according to the law.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **just**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul also wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that are "pure," or things that are not sinful in any way.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **pure**. You should use the same word that you used to translate pure earlier in the book of Philippians. For more information, refer to pure in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Paul wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that are "lovely," or things that are worthy of love.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **lovely**. Pause this audio here.

Paul also wants the Philippian Christians to think about things that people should admire or respect.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **things that people should admire**. Pause this audio here.

Paul says if anything is excellent or worthy of praise, the Philippian Christians should think about it. If something is excellent, then that thing is very good. Paul here means things that God considers good.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **excellent**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

If something is worthy of praise, then people approve of that thing and say good things about it. Probably, Paul means things that God admires or approves of.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **worthy of praise**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. For more information about praise, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 4:2–9

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (816 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

Philippians 4:10–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear Philippians 4:10—23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:10—23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.

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6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:10—23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passages, Paul told the Christians in Philippi some final things Paul wanted them to do. In this passage Paul thanks the Christians in Philippi for the help they have given Paul. Paul also finishes his letter to the Christians in Philippi.

First, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that Paul has joy because of Paul's relationship with the Lord. Paul is rejoicing in the Lord greatly because the Christians in Philippi have shown again that they are concerned for Paul. Paul clarifies that the Christians in Philippi were concerned for Paul before, but the Philippian Christians did not have an opportunity to show their concern because Paul was in a different city than Philippi. Now, Paul is talking about the fact that the Christians in Philippi sent Paul a gift while Paul was in prison. You will remember that Paul was a prisoner in a house in Rome because Paul taught about Jesus. The prison guards did not give the prisoners clothes or food or anything else. Instead, the people who cared about the prisoner would give the prisoner what they needed. So the Christians in Philippi showed that they cared about Paul because they sent a gift to Paul to help Paul survive while he was in prison.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people punish people who commit a crime? How do people take care of people who are in prison? Pause this audio here.

Paul also clarifies that Paul does not need the Philippians to give Paul anything, because Paul has learned to be content with whatever Paul has. Paul knows both how to be content when Paul is poor and when Paul has more than Paul needs. In everything and in every way, God has taught Paul deep and important things that helped Paul understand more things about God. In Paul's culture, people often formed secret groups. When people joined the secret groups, the members in the group welcomed new people by telling those people the secrets that only the people in the group knew. Paul talks about how God shared information with Paul in a similar way. God's information is not secret because God gives it to all his people, but God's information is special and helpful to God's people, and only God's people really understand what God teaches them!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people learn things that they did not know before? Are there special events that take place to show that someone has new knowledge or belongs now to a special group of people? Pause this audio here.

God has taught Paul how to be content when Paul has plenty of food, how to be content when Paul is hungry, how to be content when Paul has everything Paul needs, and how to be content when Paul must struggle to meet Paul's needs. Paul can be content through Christ, because Christ gives Paul strength. Despite Paul not needing the gift, the Christians in Philippi were kind to help Paul so that Paul had less distress.

Then Paul reminds the Philippian Christians of how they helped Paul. The Philippian Christians already know this part of the story, but Paul reminds them again that the church in Philippi was the only church that helped Paul when Paul left Macedonia, right after the Philippian Christians first started following Jesus. Macedonia was the region that the city of Philippi was located in. In fact, no church gave anything to Paul, and Paul did not receive anything from anyone except the Christians in Philippi. Even when Paul was in the city of Thessalonica near Philippi, the Christians in Philippi sent Paul some help more than once.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of Macedonia, Philippi, and Thessalonica. Pause this audio here.

Paul is not trying to get a gift from the Christians in Philippi. Instead, Paul wants the believers to do good things for a different reason. Paul compares the good things Philippian believers are doing to help Paul preach the good news to adding money to a bank account. In that time, people put their money or valuable things in a bank, which was a person or organization that takes care of and loans valuable things like money. A bank also paid people a little money so that the bank could use the money for loans or other things. So Paul is talking about the gift that the Christians in Philippi gave Paul as if it were money that the Christians put in a bank with God, and God will give the Christians in Philippi rewards for the money they gave.

Philippians 4:10–23

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, where do people put their money or valuable things? How can people earn money with the money they put in a bank? Pause this audio here.

Paul has received everything Paul needs and more. Paul is fully satisfied since Epaphroditus brought the gifts that the Christians in Philippi sent to Paul. Paul calls this gift a fragrant offering, a sacrifice that God accepts and is pleased with. Paul compares the gift that the believers in Philippi gave to an animal that people sacrifice to God. Long ago, God gave the Israelite people instructions on how to bring animals as a gift to honor God. When the Israelites offered these animals as a sacrifice in the way God instructed, the Israelites pleased God and God accepted the sacrifice. In the same way, God is pleased when the Philippian believers give a gift to help people like Paul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people sacrifice to a god? How do people make these sacrifices? Pause this audio here.

Because the Christians in Philippi helped Paul, Paul's God will fully satisfy every need that the Christians in Philippi have. God will satisfy these needs from the glorious riches that God gives through Christ Jesus. Then, Paul glorifies, or praises, God, who is also our Father, forever.

Stop here and discuss as a group about a time when you have seen God provide many good things for God's people who follow Christ Jesus. Pause this audio here.

Finally, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to greet every saint, or holy person in Christ Jesus who is in Philippi. You will remember that every Christian who trusts in Christ Jesus is holy, or set apart, for God. These people are saints. Paul often ended his letters with greetings like this.

The brothers and sisters who are with Paul in Rome send a greeting to the Christians in Philippi. The rest of the saints, or holy people, in Rome also greet the Christians in Philippi. Even the people or servants in Caesar's household who work for Caesar greet the Christians in Philippi. Caesar is the title for the Roman emperor. These people in Caesar's household had probably become Christians, and that is why these people sent greetings to the Philippian Christians.

Finally, Paul gives the Christians in Philippi a blessing: "May the Lord Jesus Christ be kind and loving to you all."

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:10—23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three parts.

In the first part: Paul rejoices because of the way the Philippians cared for Paul and explains how Christ causes Paul to be content in any circumstance.

In the second part: Paul thanks the Philippians for their gift, especially since the Philippians are the only group that helped when Paul needed it. Paul is certain that God will reward the Philippians' generosity and will provide what the Philippians need.

In the third part: Paul finishes his letter to the Christians in Philippi.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- God
- The Christians in Philippi
- People in churches
- Epaphroditus
- The Lord Jesus Christ
- The holy people or saints, probably in Rome
- The brothers and sisters with Paul

Philippians 4:10–23

- And the saints in Caesar's household

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This is the last passage in Paul's letter to the Philippians. In this passage, Paul thanks the Christians in Philippi for the help the Christians have given Paul, and Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that God will reward them for being kind. Paul also greets the Christians in Philippi on different people's behalf.

In the first part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that Paul is rejoicing in the Lord greatly. When Paul says that Paul is rejoicing in the Lord, Paul is using special language to say that Paul is happy because Paul has a relationship with the Lord. In this case, Paul is probably referring to Jesus as "Lord," or master.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you talk about how Paul rejoices because Paul has a good relationship with the Lord? Pause this audio here.

Paul is rejoicing in the Lord greatly because the Christians in Philippi have finally shown concern again for Paul. So that Paul does not sound like he is criticizing the Philippians, Paul clarifies that he knows that the believers were concerned for Paul before, but they did not have an opportunity to show their concern. Paul is talking about the fact that the Christians in Philippi sent Paul a gift while Paul was in prison.

Even though Paul is thankful for the gift, Paul explains that Paul is content no matter what happens. When someone is content, that person does not need anything else. Paul is not talking about this gift because Paul needs more and wants the believers to give again. Instead, Paul has learned to be content when Paul has very little money, and Paul has learned to be content when Paul has a lot of valuable things. In everything and in every way, God has taught Paul deep and important things. God's information is special and very important to God's people, and only God's people really understand the things God teaches them. In this way, God has taught Paul the "secret" of being content in every situation—Paul has all that Paul needs!

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to translate when Paul says that God has taught Paul the "secret" of being content in every situation? Pause this audio here.

Paul talks about what God has taught Paul with two sets of opposite phrases. Both of these phrases express the same idea with different words. First, God has taught Paul how to be content when Paul has plenty of food or when Paul is hungry. Second, God has taught Paul how to be content when Paul has plenty of valuable things or when Paul struggles to meet Paul's needs.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people talk about being rich versus being poor? How will you talk about having a lot of food versus being hungry? How will you talk about having plenty of valuable things versus struggling to get what you need? Pause this audio here.

Paul can do all these things, or be content, through the one who strengthens Paul. When Paul talks about the "one," Paul is talking about Christ, but Paul does not actually use the name Christ. Paul probably means that Paul can be content in all of these situations because Christ helps Paul. Christ causes Paul to be strong in every kind of circumstance.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you say that Paul says that he can do all these things through Christ who gives Paul strength? Pause this audio here.

Despite Paul not needing the gift, the Christians in Philippi were kind to share Paul's distress. When Paul says that the Christians in Philippi share his distress, Paul is using special language to mean that the Philippians helped Paul so that Paul had less distress.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When did someone help you when you were experiencing a difficult time? How do you describe the way that the other person helped you when you were in trouble? What is the best way to translate when Paul said that the Christians in Philippi share Paul's distress? Pause this audio here.

Paul continues to talk about the way that the Christians in Philippi have helped Paul. The Philippians know this story, so Paul is probably reminding the Philippians of this to praise and encourage the Philippians. When the Philippians had first heard the gospel, the Philippians helped Paul when Paul traveled through Macedonia. When Paul talks about the early days of the gospel, Paul means that Paul had not shared the gospel in very many

places yet, and not very many people in Philippi had started to follow Jesus. In fact, no church joined giving and receiving with Paul except the Christians in Philippi. When Paul talks about giving and receiving, Paul is probably talking about churches or groups of Christians giving money to Paul, and Paul receiving that money from them. Paul might also be talking about how Paul gave by teaching the people about Jesus, and then the people gave back by giving Paul money. Even when Paul was in the city of Thessalonica, the Christians in Philippi sent Paul some help more than once.

Paul is not trying to get a gift from the Christians in Philippi. Instead, Paul wants the believers to receive something! Paul uses business terms to talk about what happens when the believers give. When Paul talks about the profit in their account, Paul is using special language. In Paul's culture, people often used organizations called banks to hold their money or things that are valuable. The bank also paid people a little money so that the bank could use the money for loans or other things. So Paul is talking about the gift that the Christians in Philippi gave Paul as if it were money that they put in a bank with God, and God will give the Christians in Philippi rewards for the money they gave. When the Philippian Christians do things for God, it is like they are adding to their bank account with God. Paul also uses this special language to emphasize that the Philippians do not owe Paul anything; Paul has received everything that the Philippians owed Paul.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about financial matters? When would you compare something like a gift to interest on an account? What is the best way to translate when Paul says he wants the Christians in Philippi to make a profit in their account? Pause this audio here.

Paul has received everything Paul needs and more. Paul is fully satisfied since Epaphroditus brought the gifts that the Christians in Philippi sent to Paul. Paul compares this gift to a fragrant offering, a sacrifice that God accepts and is pleased with. Paul is using special language by talking as if the gift the Christians in Philippi gave was an animal they sacrificed to God. God often talked about animals that people sacrificed as acceptable and pleasing to God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The Old Testament describes in Exodus 29 how the Israelites were supposed to give sacrifices. In Exodus 29:38—41, the storyteller describes a sacrifice that pleases God. If you have already translated this passage, how could you use similar language here? What is the best way to translate when Paul calls the gift a fragrant offering? Pause this audio here.

Because the Christians in Philippi helped Paul, Paul's God will fully satisfy every need that the Christians in Philippi have. God will satisfy these needs from the "glorious," or great, riches that God gives through Jesus Christ. Paul might also mean that God has this great wealth because of what Jesus Christ has done. Then, Paul wishes for people to glorify the God and Father of Paul and the Christians in Philippi forever and ever. Paul is both praising God and urging others to praise God too. When Paul says forever and ever, Paul is using special language to mean that Paul wants people to glorify, or praise, God forever. People often said things like forever and ever to emphasize something that is certain and true, and that never ends.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you praise God? How do you urge others to praise God? How do you talk about things that last forever or should last forever? What is the best way to translate when Paul says that he wants people to glorify God forever and ever? Pause this audio here.

Paul ends this part by saying "amen," which means that Paul wants this prayer to be true.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you finish a prayer and say that you want that prayer to be true? How will you say "amen" here? Pause this audio here.

In the second part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to greet every holy person in Christ Jesus. The holy people, or saints, are people who obey Jesus and have a close relationship with Jesus. When Paul talks about people as being "in Christ," Paul means that they belong to Christ. Paul is telling the Christians in Philippi to greet the other believers they meet on Paul's behalf.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people send greetings to people they can not talk to personally? What words do people use to describe the greetings? How will you talk about Paul telling the Christians in Philippi to greet the holy people, or "saints," in Christ Jesus? Pause this audio here.

Philippians 4:10–23

Paul also sends a greeting to the Christians in Philippi from three groups of people. First, the brothers and sisters with Paul send a greeting to the Christians in Philippi. Some people think these brothers and sisters were the people directly helping Paul while Paul was in prison. Second, the other holy people, or saints, also greet the Christians in Philippi. Paul is probably talking about the other believers in Rome, not all the holy people in the whole world. Third, the people in Caesar's household also greet the Christians in Philippi. Caesar was the emperor, or the person in charge of the entire Roman Empire, which included Philippi. The people in Caesar's household were probably servants who worked for Caesar.

Finally, Paul gives the Christians in Philippi a blessing: "May the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit." In other words, Paul wants the Lord Jesus Christ to love the Christians in Philippi even though they do not deserve it. When Paul mentions the Christians' spirit, Paul is using special language to mean the Christians in Philippi themselves. In Paul's culture, people believed that people had a spirit, or soul, that was part of who they were and that would live after they died.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of blessings do people give each other in your culture? What specific blessings do people use for the end of a message? What kinds of words do you use in these blessings? What is the best way to translate when Paul asks for the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ to be with the spirits of the Christians in Philippi? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:10—23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- Paul
- God
- The Christians in Philippi
- People in churches
- Epaphroditus
- The Lord Jesus Christ
- The holy people or saints, probably in Rome
- The brothers and sisters with Paul
- And the saints in Caesar's household

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi that Paul is rejoicing in the Lord greatly. Paul is rejoicing in the Lord greatly because the Christians in Philippi have finally shown again that the Philippians care for Paul. Paul clarifies that the Christians in Philippi were concerned for Paul before, but the Christians did not have an opportunity to show their concern.

Philippians 4:10–23

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Christians in Philippi, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy that Paul appreciates our gift; or
- I am glad we got to show Paul how much we care about Paul; or
- We want to help Paul because Paul is doing God's work.

Continue the drama.

Paul does not say this to tell the Philippians that Paul does not have all that Paul needs. Paul has learned to be content with whatever Paul has. Paul knows both how to be content when Paul is poor and when Paul has plenty of things. In everything and in every way, Paul has learned how to be content when Paul has plenty of food or when Paul is hungry, when Paul has all he needs or when Paul does not have what Paul needs. Paul can do all these things because Christ gives Paul strength.

Even though Paul was content no matter how much Paul had, the believers were kind to send help when Paul was having difficulties. As the Christians in Philippi know, they helped Paul when he left Macedonia after the Christians in Philippi first learned the good news about Jesus. In fact, no church gave anything to Paul or accepted anything from Paul except the Christians in Philippi. Even when Paul was in the city of Thessalonica, the Christians in Philippi sent Paul some help more than once.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Paul, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am relieved that the believers in Philippi are taking care of me. I was wondering how I would be able to pay for things like food and travel! or
- I wish Christians in other churches would have taken more care of me so I can do more work for Jesus; or
- I do not need the Christians in Philippi to send me a gift because God will take care of me no matter what happens.

Continue the drama.

Paul is not trying to get a gift from the Christians in Philippi. Instead, Paul wants the Christians in Philippi to give money to Paul so that God will give even more to the Christians in Philippi. Paul has received everything the Philippians sent and it is more than enough for what Paul needs. Paul is fully satisfied since Epaphroditus brought the gifts that the Christians in Philippi sent to Paul. Paul calls this gift a fragrant offering, a sacrifice that God accepts and is pleased with.

Because the Christians in Philippi helped Paul, and because of what Christ Jesus has done, God, whom Paul worships, will give all that the Philippians need. Then, Paul prays that people will glorify the God and Father of all Christians forever, amen.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing God, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love what the Christians in Philippi are doing for Paul; or
- I will bless the Christians in Philippi because they are doing what I want them to do; or
- I have so much that I am easily able to give the Christians in Philippi everything they need.

Continue the drama.

In the second part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to greet every believer who belongs to Christ Jesus. The brothers and sisters with Paul send a greeting to the Christians in Philippi. The rest of the holy people in Rome also greet the Christians in Philippi, and the people in Caesar's household also greet the Christians in Philippi. Finally, Paul gives the Christians in Philippi a blessing: May the Lord Jesus Christ give you all grace.

Philippians 4:10–23

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of Philippians 4:10—23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this passage, Paul calls Jesus his **Lord**. A Lord is someone who is a master over other people, who has full authority, and who deserves for people to give him respect. When you address someone as "Lord," you are saying that person has authority over you. Use the same word or phrase for Lord as you used in previous passages. For more information on Lord, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Christians in Philippi helped Paul in the early days of the **gospel**, or good news. The word gospel is a translation of a Greek word that literally means "good news." The good news in the Bible is that God has made a way to save people. In the New Testament, it becomes clear that the way that God saves his people is through Jesus's death and resurrection. Use the same word or phrase for gospel as you used in previous passages. For more information on gospel, refer to the Master Glossary.

None of the other **churches** supported Paul. In the Bible, the church is a community of people who believe in Jesus. Sometimes people use the word "church" to refer to a group of believers in one specific place, and sometimes the word means all the people on earth together who believe in Jesus. Here Paul is talking about the local churches in various cities. Use the same word or phrase for church as you used in previous passages. For more information on church, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul calls the gift that the Christians in Philippi gave him a **sacrifice**. A sacrifice is a gift to God. People often placed the gift on a platform made of earth or large stones, which people called an altar. Use the same word or phrase for sacrifice as you used in previous passages. For more information on sacrifice, refer to the Master Glossary.

Because the Christians in Philippi helped Paul, God will help those Christians from his **glorious** riches. When God shows his glory, people can see how beautiful, powerful, and majestic God is. Here, the riches that God has are part of how impressive God is. Use the same word or phrase for glory as you used in previous passages. For more information on glory, refer to the Master Glossary.

The glorious riches that God has will be in **Christ** Jesus. The word "Christ" refers to the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. Use the same word or phrase for Christ as you used in previous passages. For more information on Christ, refer to the Master Glossary.

Paul tells the believers to **glorify** the believers' God and Father forever. When people glorify God, people praise God, admire God, and say good things about God. Use the same word or phrase for glory as you used earlier in this passage and in previous passages. For more information on glory, refer to the Master Glossary.

After Paul tells the believers to glorify God, Paul says, "Amen." When someone offers a prayer to God, you can say "Amen." This means that you hope and believe that the prayer will be answered.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **amen**. Look up amen in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In the second part, Paul tells the Christians in Philippi to greet every holy person, or **saint**. The word saints simply means "holy people." In the New Testament, all followers of Jesus are holy people, or saints. Use the same word or phrase for saint as you used in previous passages. For more information on saint, refer to the Master Glossary.

The **brothers** greet the Christians in Philippi. Paul often calls Christians "brothers" or "brothers and sisters" because Christians are like members of the same family with God as their father. Use the same word or phrase for brothers as you used in previous passages.

The saints in Caesar's household greet the Christians in Philippi. Caesar is the title for the Roman emperor.

Philippians 4:10–23

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Caesar**. Look up Caesar in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In the Bible, a "household" means all the people who are living together. The father was usually the leader of the "house," or household. The household included the man's wife, children, unmarried daughters, and any married sons and their wives and children. Other relatives might also live with this family. If the family had servants or slaves, then the family included the servants in the household as well. In this passage, the members of Caesar's household who became Christians are probably servants.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **household**. Look up household in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Paul also prays for the **grace** of Jesus to be with the **spirit** of the Christians in Philippi. When someone shows us grace, that person does something good for us, or gives us something good that we do not deserve. Use the same word or phrase for grace as you used in previous passages. For more information on grace, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Bible calls the invisible part of a person that controls what they think a **spirit**. Here, Paul is talking about that part of a person to talk about the entire person. Use the same word or phrase for spirit, when it refers to a person, as you used in previous passages. For more information on spirit, refer to the Master Glossary.

Media Requests:

A map of Greece that shows Macedonia, Philippi, and Thessalonica

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

Philippians 4:10–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (845 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.9 MB)

Philippians 4:10–23

- Embodying the Text (3.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)